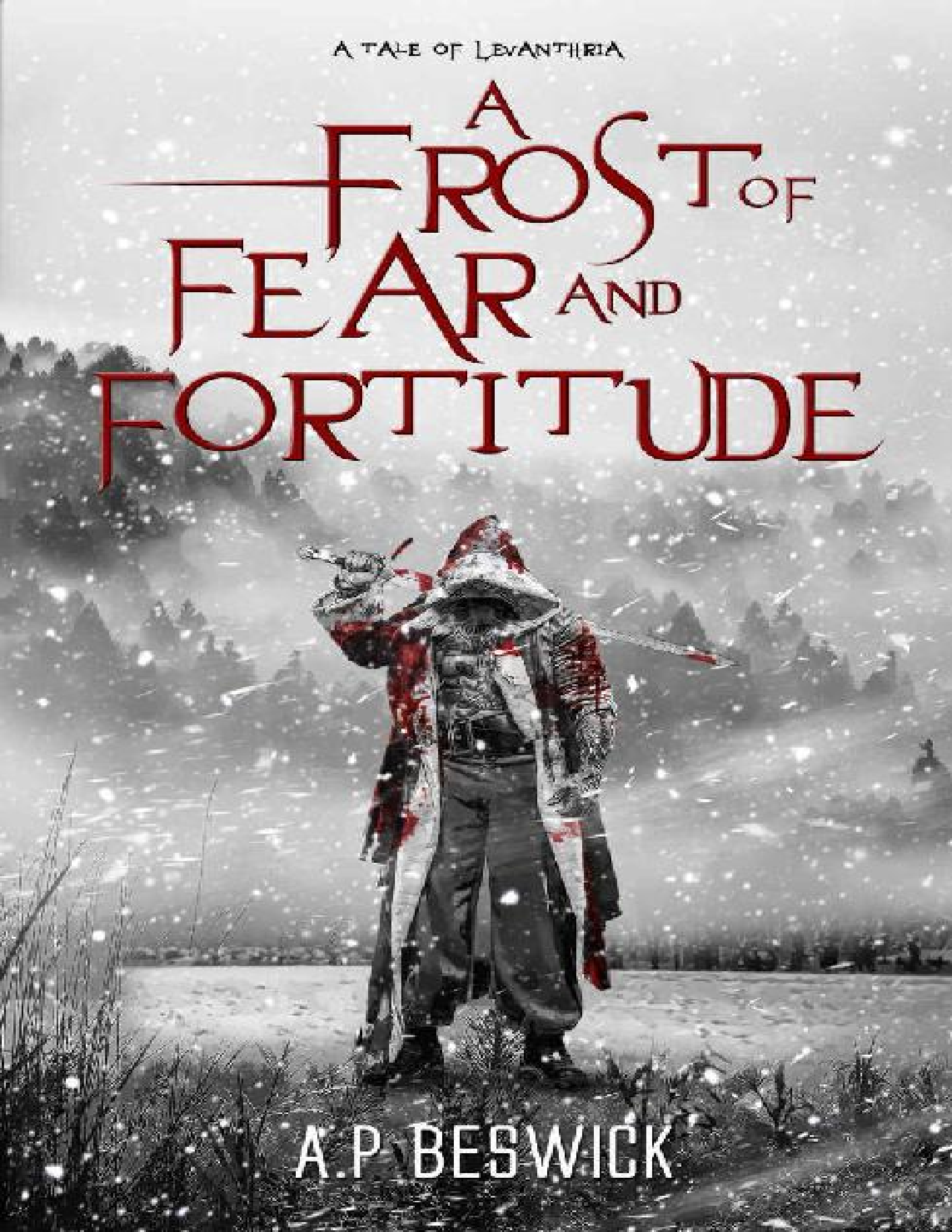
A TALE OF LEVANTHIRIA

A FROST OF FEAR AND FORTITUDE



A.P BESWICK

A Frost of Fear and Fortitude

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And finally a thank you to you, the reader, who has helped me grow this series to a level I could only ever dream of.

Legends are not born, they are forged!

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THE LEGENDS OF LEVANTHRIA

This series was published thanks to backers on Kickstarter. This page is to thank the legends that have backed the highest tiers in my previous Kickstarter campaigns.

The Merry Men And Women…..
Seth (The Little) Alexander
Joshua (The Scarlett) Grey
Daniel (The Friar) Dorman
Robin (The Hood) Hill

The Legendary Pieces Of Eight
Seth (Blackbeard) Alexander
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Sleigh Bells Ring.... Are You Listening?

To the legends that backed the highest tier on Kickstarter for A Fear Of Frost And Fortitude.

Seth (Dasher) Alexander
Brian Ray (Dancer) Knoblich
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Christian A. (Prancer) Palmelund
Christian (Comit) Mays
Curtis (Bltzen) Boudreau
Colin (Donner) McCarthy
Kat (Rudolph)Brady
Odin Barth (Cupid) Oyvindsonn

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A Loch Of Grace And Greed
Dust
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PROLOGUE

On a winding icy road bereft of life, a sleigh travelled slowly through the snow-filled landscape. Powder made the terrain difficult to navigate but the animals that pulled the sleigh were accustomed to the hostilities that this weather inflicted. Two men sat at the front, clad in fur-lined coats with thick scarfs wrapped around their necks, their hoods drawn over their heads. A layer of ice formed in their facial hair.

Inside the carriage, a well-dressed man used to the fineries of life appeared pensive as he looked out the window at the vast landscape of nothing: a barren wasteland of ice surrounded them for as far as he could see, a far cry from the warmer shores of Levanthria. The arduous ride to this point had taken nearly two months.

The man opened his jacket and withdrew a map etched with crosses over the towns and villages they had already passed through. He glances out the window at the sun before addressing the crinkled map once more. They should not be too far from their destination now. He ran his hand down his weary face, tracing the lines of age that tracked his dark eyes.

“Father, how long will you be away?” The final words of his daughter before he set off on this journey played in his mind over and over. His anticipation of seeing the smiling faces of his twin daughters again was the main motivation that kept him going. After this task was done, he was finished with this life. He would return to his family and live out the rest of his days not worrying about where the next trade was coming from. His purses would be swelled enough to ensure his daughters’ lives would be taken care of, enough to ensure that their children and grandchildren would

prosper. This would be his legacy. He just needed to transport the contents of the carriage to the location given to him.

The package had arrived bound and sealed with a letter simply saying not to open it, and for Gregor himself to transport it to the northern plains beyond Levanthria. It was a landscape not explored by many, but the promise of coin evidenced by the down payment he had received alongside the package was enough to convince him that this was his chance to leave. To be rid of the dark world that he had known for so long.

Gregor wasn't a good man. He told himself that he did what he did to provide his daughters with the best lives possible, but deep down, he knew that this was a lie.

There was one question that had traced through his thoughts for the last two months: just who was it that had sent the package? Who had made this request of him? He had doubted the move himself and contemplated sending someone else to do his bidding, but the letter was specific: it had to be him who delivered the package, whatever it was.

It had sat opposite him in the carriage for the entire journey. Given how valuable it was, he had opted to keep it near him. He was more than curious as to what it contained but he had remained resolute about not looking inside the box. Until today.

Something ate at his mind like a rat gnawing on a rope. Something that Gregor simply could not let go of. Today, more than ever, he found the temptation to open it simply too much. It was a feeling that had steadily been growing inside him, as though the farther they travelled and the closer they got to the destination, the stronger the urge became.

Gregor lowered the map and stared longingly at the box. He stretched out his hand towards the mysterious item.

A sudden jolt snapped him back into the room and the carriage rumbled and creaked. Gregor had no idea what had caused the commotion but for some reason his carriage men had lost control.

The carriage spun quickly onto its side, removing Gregor from his seat. His vision whirled as wild as the winds that engulfed them. With a crash, the side of the cart ripped open, wood splintering into Gregor's skin. By the time the carriage stopped, Gregor had found himself catapulted through the thick snow where he lay on his back, gasping for air. A warmth trickled down his face where blood seeped from a gash on his forehead. Heaving himself to his knees, he groaned as he desperately tried to see what had

caused the accident. Ahead of him, his sleigh lay in ruin, broken and wasted. The carriage men were nowhere to be seen. Stranger still, the sudden storm had vanished as quickly as it arrived.

Gregor's heart raced as he stumbled towards the wreckage. He was in the middle of nowhere. If he was to travel on foot, he would not have long before the elements killed him. Desperation seeped in and tears formed in his eyes at the realisation that if he was to meet his end, he would not lay eyes on either of his daughters again.

Gregor spotted the strange, dark wood box protruding from the disintegrated wreckage, undamaged. When he reached it, he heaved it from the snow and placed it level in front of him. He hesitated for a moment, casting his eyes over it. If he was to die on this day, he wanted to know what was inside all this time.

Tentatively, Gregor opened the box. No sooner that he did than a flash of light blinded his vision, causing him to shield his eyes. He closed them tight, but the light remained burning into him. Excruciating pain knocked him back into the snow. The last thing Gregor saw as he tried to gather himself was the silhouette of a glowing woman with snake-like tattoos coiled up her arms. She moved towards him as if she had come from the afterlife to bring him to rest.

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CHAPTER
ONE

There was nothing around. His existence had been extinguished by the blade that protruded from his abdomen, and blood flowed around his corpse, forming veins in the ice like lava spewed down a volcano's surface. The aged man remembered the darkness creeping towards him as he took his final breaths, but nothing afterwards. The coolness of the ice against the back of his head became nothing as his life slowly dripped away. Before the darkness, nothing. His memories eroded like a wave crashing into a cliff.

When the man opened his eyes, he was greeted by nothing. His immediate surroundings were whiter than the freshest of snow. No trees, no houses or terrain. It was as though he were suspended in a void.

Feeling a sharp pain in his stomach, he looked down to see a sword embedded in his torso. Not just any sword, but a broadsword. The thick blade's weight pulled him forward, and he searched his hands around his back to find that the blade had gone straight through him and out the other side. Clasping hold of the hilt, he began the painful process of removing it, feeling every inch of the weapon as it slid reluctantly through his broken flesh.

"How am I not dead?" His hoarse voice was like gravel. It was a voice he did not recognise. In fact, he did not recognise anything. He was bereft of memories, replaced by a darkness and an empty feeling that had greeted him when he met death.

"You are neither dead nor alive," a deep male voice echoed around him, startling the man.

"Have I descended into madness?"

“You have descended from chaos,” the powerful voice replied, resonating as if standing in a great hall, but the injured man remained standing in an empty void, alone.

“You have greeted death, murdered at the hands of another that should not walk your lands. You are not done with this world though.” The voice paused. “I have work you must carry out at my request. If you do this, then one day I may grant you the peace that comes with death and honour.”

“What of my life? What is it that you want of me?” The pain in the man’s stomach gradually faded to nothing more than a dull ache.

“Your mind is clear,” the voice continued. “The life you led cannot distract you if you cannot remember the life you led. As for what I request of you, there is a darkness in the land. I need you to rid this darkness of its purpose.”

“How? How am I meant to defeat darkness?” The words spilled from the man’s mouth in frustration.

“The darkness controls the creatures, the demons that stalk this land. I need you to find them and destroy them before they threaten to overrun your world.”

“Who are you?”

“Someone with more power than your mind can comprehend. Someone with the ability to bring you back from the dead and grant you increased strength and heightened senses. Although not immortal, you will age at a rate far slower than those who walk these lands.”

“If you are all powerful, why do you not rid the world of these creatures yourself?” the man demanded.

“It is forbidden for me to physically walk your planes, but that does not mean I cannot have influence. Your sole purpose now is to search for the darkness and extinguish the chaos it hopes to bring. Destroy the demons, stop the darkness from corrupting people of your world.”

The aged man’s eyes fluttered open to the stars that littered the night sky above him. Trying to bring himself upright, he struggled, his limbs unmoving, rigid. Moving his head to the right, he looked down his arm. A layer of frost lined the surface.

How long have I been here?

Focusing on his frozen arm, he tensed his muscles. It was as if his thoughts could not reach his limbs. Undeterred, he tried again, and this time, his arm slowly moved as he pulled it up from the snow. Wiggling his

fingers was a strange sensation as the blood pulsed through his arm, bringing a warmth to it. His fingers cracked and crunched like breaking bones, and he gritted his teeth in discomfort. He let out a cry of pain as his arm reluctantly snapped at the joint. Then the man rocked slightly before heaving himself upright. Around him there was whiteness, but rather than suspended in nothing, he was guarded by a frozen terrain and clear blue sky.

Casting his eyes down his body, he realised that the brownish red ice around him was his own frozen blood. The sword he had removed in his dream now sat atop the snow, decorated with red. Curiously, no frost coated the blade. Although he sat semi-frozen in the ice, he did not feel the cold as he would expect. Sure, his body ached as it thawed, and he could feel every bone of his body cracking as it snapped back to life. The blood pumping around his body brought about a sensation of multiple small nails stabbing and jabbing at his skin. But he wasn't cold.

With an almighty heave, the man threw himself onto his side, pulling his legs free of the ice. They crunched as he crawled onto all fours, fighting a wave of nausea and dizziness that suddenly overcame him. After a few moments, knowing that he could not sit by idly forever, he opted to fight through the pain barrier and slowly managed to plant one of his feet, followed by the other. The crunch of the snow underfoot paled in comparison to the noise his frosted joints made.

Just how long had he been here? Who had killed him—or at the very least, tried to? As hard as the man tried, he could search nothing in his mind, his thoughts greeted with a thickened fog that blocked his memories. The harder he tried to think back to his past, the thicker the fog seemed. The furthest back he could remember was the dream he was having before he awoke.

Judging by the fact that he awoke in snow with a sword injury that would kill any other man, all he could do was take the words of the mysterious voice to be true. He reached for the broadsword and gripped the handle with both hands. When he touched the blade, he felt as though it soothed part of his soul, giving him a comfort not too dissimilar to a warm blanket in front of a fire. The hilt was warm to the touch, a red gem embedded in a circular node at the bottom. The warmth spread across his body, and though he could not feel the cold, it did not lessen the sensation of the heat. The sun shone brightly down on him, and he could hear the ice thawing from the warmth of the blade, which vibrated gently. Its warmth

pulsated over him in waves from where his hands gripped the hilt, until his body felt less stiff, unfrozen.

The man knew that what lay before him was a broadsword, the blade itself longer and wider than a more commonly found blade, and heavier. But he found it confusing that he knew what the weapon was, despite not having any memories. Was it only his past and his identity that was to remain shrouded? Why would someone do this to him? Why would someone murder him?

All he knew at this stage was that he could not stay in this bleak, frozen landscape forever, and he needed to move on. As he leant forward, he planted his feet, readying himself to pick the blade up from the snow. As he did so, his long, wet hair reached over the front of his face and he noticed it was a whitish grey.

Just how old am I? he thought. He felt lost with little guidance of what to do other than 'fight the creatures of the darkness.'

When he lifted the sword from the snow, the blade was not as heavy as he imagined, something that caused him to overcompensate and fall backwards. He just about managed to stay upright, and he gathered himself as he gave the blade a once-over. He felt drawn to it, connected to it. He knew from the heat that the sword emitted that this was like no other sword he had laid eyes on, that this sword, somehow, had magic imbued into it. At least if he carried this blade, the man would not find himself frozen in the snow once more, forgotten by the people of Levanthria.

Steam left his body as the man took his first few steps in the snow. Walking felt strange. His ability to do simple things seemed a little disjointed, and his legs felt foreign to him, his muscle memory having long faded, just as his memories. But it didn't take him too long to get the gist of walking once more, the sound of the crushing snow underfoot and the whistle from the icy winds around him the only thing to distract him from his thoughts.

"The creatures are controlled by a darkness," he muttered to himself. Was this to be his purpose now, was this all he was alive to do, without even a say in the matter? One thing he did know was that whatever had given him life could just as easily take it away from him.

The aged man continued his path through the crisp, untouched snow. He had no idea how long it would take for him to find shelter but the sword gave him energy and warmth, and he did not feel the pain of hunger.

What else can this sword do? He was sure that it would only be a matter of time before he found out.

Find the darkness.

That was what he must do.

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CHAPTER
TWO

The moon sat high in the night sky, not quite full but almost at its completed cycle. There were few clouds, giving the stars a chance to shine brightly and dazzle throughout the night.

"It was because of this that the goddess Reeva returned to her star. It is because of this that she sits high enough in the sky to keep watch over us all. So that she can ensure that we remain good people." Horus Glesh leant forward and ruffled the dark brown hair of his boy, whose auburn eyes blinked as he fought the inevitable sleep that would soon befall him, a patch of freckles decorating his nose. "Come on, son, it's time for you to get some sleep."

Horus, along with his wife, Gleya, worked all day on their small farm. Because of the time of year, the days were growing shorter, the nights longer and colder. It didn't lessen the burden of work they needed to complete each day, and on this particular crisp, clear night, he was exhausted. Along with his ten-year-old son, Colt, Horus had twin daughters Freya and Shae who were six years old. It had been just over a year since they moved to the little town far north of the Pendaren Hills called Garuvia.

Not for the fainthearted, Garuvia was known for its harsh cold weather, often leaving the plains coated in a snow colder than anywhere else across Levanthria for most of the year. Opting to relocate his family to such harsh conditions was not an easy decision for Horus, but the opportunity to take over his own yakula farm was too good to turn down. Yakula fur sold for a high price, and with its ability to protect from the cold, it was sometimes rumoured to have magical properties. The large creatures were not too

dissimilar to a goat, only standing far taller at around five feet, with large vertical horns like thick branches from an oak tree.

Up until now, Horus's plan had worked. He and his family had a modest cottage and land to boot. They did not have to worry about money or providing food for their family because with their farm they were relatively self-sufficient. They lived a happy life once they had become accustomed to the cold.

"Is that really what Reeva does, Pops?"

Horus pointed towards the small window at the far side of the room. "See that star there, the brightest one in the sky? That's where she sits, that is where she watches. Remember, if you do not help others or act selflessly, she will not show kindness in return. Be kind to others. It is a principle that too many forget to live by." Horus paused for a moment as if circulating his own thoughts, before stirring from the distraction. "Do you want to know the best thing, Colt?" Horus said.

"What, Pops?"

"It doesn't cost anything to be kind, not one single coin." Horus leant forward to give Colt another kiss on the head as his son shuffled down under his quilt and onto his side. He wanted his son to grow to be a better person than himself.

"Goodnight, son."

"Goodnight, Pops." Colt let out a yawn that was big enough to swallow all the air in the room.

It had been a busy day for Horus, but he cherished these moments. He took one last look over Colt before pulling the door shut. Colt could hear each of his pop's footsteps as the stairs creaked beneath him.

Colt shut his eyes and slowly began to drift off to sleep.

A loud thud snapped Colt awake. He searched the room but all he could see was darkness. Thinking he had imagined it, Colt lowered his head back onto his pillow before closing his eyes once more.

A second thud startled him again, followed by the sound of plates smashing on the floor. Colt sat bolt upright. Maybe his mother or father had dropped the plates carrying their tea. After all, Colt knew that the two of them ate their tea once he and his sisters were asleep.

"Get back!" came Horus's muffled voice from downstairs.

Another loud thud reached Colt this time, followed by a more destructive sound, as though the table had been flipped over.

Colt lay frozen, his heart rate rapidly increasing. His mother's shrill scream pierced his ears, causing the hairs on his arms to stand on end. As quickly and loudly as his mother began screaming, the noise was cut short, followed by another sickening thud.

Colt's thoughts instantly went to his sisters whose room sat opposite his. He darted from his bed and raced for the door. He did this as quietly as he could, trying not to alert whoever was downstairs. He pushed open the door, his hand trembling uncontrollably, then shot across the landing. He snuck into his sisters' room, quickly shutting the door behind him.

"Ma?" Shae called out to the darkness.

"What was that scream?" Freya asked, her voice raised.

"Shhh." Colt needed them both to be quiet before they drew attention to them all. "I don't know what's happening, but we are going to play a little game, okay?" He moved towards the two small bed frames on the far side of the room. Colt couldn't see, but he was guided by his memory. His foot kicked something solid on the wooden floor, causing him to stumble. When he reached the end of one of the beds, Freya wrapped her arms around him tightly, trembling.

"Colt, I'm scared," she whispered.

"You need to listen to me." He felt something to his side and reached out to find Shae also clinging onto him now. Colt was just as scared as his sisters, but he had a deep feeling that he needed to be brave for the two of them. His mouth was dry, his words difficult to find in this moment. "We're going to play a game of hide-and-seek, okay?"

Shae and Freya nodded in tandem, and Colt squeezed them both as tight as he could.

"I need you both to hide. Make it as good as you can."

"How about under our beds?" Freya asked.

"That sounds like a really good idea, be quick though, and quiet."

His sisters separated from him and crawled into the small spaces under their beds. Colt pulled up the sheets and passed them down.

"Now I need both of you to be as quiet as possible. Don't make a sound." He started moving for the door.

"Where are you going, Colt?" Shae asked louder than Colt would have liked.

"I'm going to check on Ma and Pops. Remember, don't make a noise." With this, he reached for the door and gently pushed it open before stepping

into the small, narrow hallway.

The glow from the candlelight downstairs kissed the top of the stairs as if the light was teasing Colt to step forward. Though the light brought some sense of reassurance, Colt rather felt that sticking to the shadows was safer. He needed to know that his mother and father were okay, so he stepped towards the top of the stairs. There was no movement other than the creeping shadows caused by the flickering flames. No mumbled words, only an eerie silence. Colt descended the stairs slowly, his heart beating rapidly against his young chest. He had never known fear like this. All he knew was that he needed to stay brave for his sisters. His legs felt as if they could give way as he crept down the stairs, looking for his parents.

When he reached the bottom step, he was taken aback by the themes that greeted him. Plates and bottles were smashed over the floor. The kitchen table was on its side, one of the legs broken clean in half. Colt noticed a pair of feet sticking out from behind the table.

“Pops!” He frantically clambered across the carnage to get to him. A stinging sensation greeted him as his feet trampled through the broken glass, but Colt barely had time to notice. He reached the end of the table to find his father laid out on the floor, a gaping hole in his chest. Colt retched at the sight of the muscle and sinew on display from his father’s fatal wound, a pool of blood surrounding him, his mouth wide open in a look of horror and surprise.

“Pops, no, no, no, no!” Colt began rocking wildly. “Wake up, Pops, please wake up.” He shook his father, trying to stir him into consciousness, but his efforts were in vain. Horus had passed from this world and Colt did not know what to do with himself.

Tears stung Colt’s face as they streamed down his blushed cheeks. He could not fight back the sobs any longer and began crying inconsolably. His chest grew tight, and he found it hard to breath as he continued to shake his father. It was only a few moments ago that Horus had been tucking him up into bed with a story. Now he was gone, and Colt would never hear him utter another word.

Barely having time to process what had happened to his father, Colt looked around the room and what remained of his heart, of his hope, quickly shattered into more pieces than the broken glass and plates that surrounded him. To his left, just beyond his line of sight, his mother sat hunched in a chair, her head bent backwards, revealing a large, clawed gash

across her throat. Her arms were draped to either side of her, the blood still spurting from her neck.

“Ma!” Colt sprang from the floor and rushed to his mother. He didn’t know what to do, how to make everything better. He grabbed hold of his mother’s hand and squeezed. “Ma, not you too. Wake up, please wake up, Ma.” He shook her hand but again she remained still in death. Her head motioned as it bobbed to the side, her mouth agape, frozen with her final scream. Colt stepped back from her, his horror like nothing a child of his age should ever experience. His heels hit his father’s body and he toppled backwards. With a crash, he slammed into the side of one of the cupboards and a sharp pain engulfed the back of his head. His vision instantly blurred, and he was forced to shut his eyes to cope with the pain. Unable to fight the gurgling feeling in his stomach any longer, Colt vomited over himself where he sat slumped against the wall. The bile in his throat burned as he emptied the contents of his stomach. The nausea and the combined dizziness paled in comparison to the fear and grief that engulfed him like a flame. As the stinging and blurred vision subsided, something caught Colt’s eye in the corner of the room and his heart sank even further than he thought possible.

Purple eyes glowed at the bottom of the stairs. He couldn’t make out the body of whatever stood in front of him but he knew by its spectral presence that it was responsible for the death that lay around him. Its eyes hung in the air before the creature began to climb the steps towards where his sisters were hiding.

Colt made to move forward but found that he couldn’t; dizziness was getting worse. The purple glowing eyes began swirling around before him. They reached the top of the stairs as Colt’s heart descended even further, deeper into his stomach like a boat sinking into the dark ocean, and he drifted into unconsciousness.

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CHAPTER
THREE

Sitting around the campfire was a frustrating and tiresome process for the aged man. For three days straight he found himself needing to stop his endless walk through the frozen landscape. Unaffected by the cold and finding that he did not need or desire sleep, it was the darkness that forced him to stop. Darkness could be disorienting and he had wasted a full day following the trodden tracks he had already walked. He lit the fire to bring light, not forged through the burning of wood but by the heated glow of his blade.

The broadsword was truly a magical blade infused with the powers of the gods. The question was, which god? He found the more he walked, the more he had time to ponder his thoughts, the more he grew confused over the newfound path he was on. He knew how to walk, how to talk, how to wield his blade. His mind was filled with the knowledge and experience that living a long and fruitful life should bring. But the harder he focused on the dark hole in his mind, the further away it felt. He had no idea who he was or how he had gained his knowledge. What he knew now was that he needed to walk and find a village or town so he could figure out exactly where he was. Maybe then he could find some answers to the life he once lived.

Using a dagger he had found inside his jacket, the man whittled a piece of wood into the shape of a blade whilst he waited for the darkness to move on, then placed it in front of his flaming sword and let out a sigh. All he needed to do now was wait for the sun to rise so he could continue his long walk. Judging by the fading stars, he would not be waiting much longer.

A flicker from his broadsword caught the man’s attention and he stared intently at the weapon. Deep in thought, he ruffled his thick matted beard, feeling himself drawn forward, as if being pulled by strings. He tensed his muscles, fighting against the invisible force. The dagger he had just whittled began to hum. He picked it up, and to his surprise, the dagger was vibrating intensely. The force of the vibration tickled his hand at first, but within a few seconds, an ache in his palm travelled up to his forearm. He tried to release the dagger but found that he could not. The more he tried, the tighter his grip appeared to become. The ache began to consume him, and when the flames changed to a dark green, the man felt a connection to the magic within. Slowly he could feel the pressure pushing back down his arm towards the wooden dagger. When the pain was isolated in his clenched fist, he brought his free hand over and concentrated, guided by instinct, as if the blade were speaking to him.

A green glow that matched the colour of the flames emitted from his palm and engulfed his sword, which still lay by the crackling fire. The magic in his hand released a flash of light, illuminating his surroundings like a fork of lighting.

The sword glowed its brightest just as the man heard movement around him, and he was greeted with a tremendous blow that sent him sprawling out through the snow.

Ignoring the pain on his side, the man quickly climbed to his knees to see what had hit him. The sun was beginning to rise, and he was able to see the creature in its full form as it slithered towards him.

The man knew straight away that it was a frost wyrm. A descendant of a dragon, the wyrm was serpentine in appearance. Polished black in colour, its rough, scaled body was around ten feet long, meaning this wyrm was relatively young. Its eyes were different from a frost wyrm’s usual yellow colour, and they glowed with a blueish-purple haze. It opened its mouth to reveal rows of sharp, jagged teeth, then took a wild lunge at him. He dived to the side to dodge the blow, then rose and rushed towards the wyrm with his broadsword. He knew how to kill a wyrm, and this confused him, his mind awash with ideas of how to survive such an attack. His instincts told him that the wyrm’s weak spot was its crest as it sat upright. When he placed his hand on the hilt of his broadsword, the flames around it ignited fiercely and burned green once more. In an instant, his aching side numbed and his arms and legs felt energised with newfound strength. No sooner had

he grabbed the blade, his feet were swiped from underneath him by the wyrm's tail.

He rolled onto his back just as the beast lunged forward to take a bite out of him. He heaved his broadsword into the side of the wyrm's head, and sparks flew as metal met stone-like skin. The blow was enough to divert the wyrm to the side and allow the man time to return to his feet. Unrelenting, the wyrm darted forward, attempting to strike, but its movement seemed unnatural. Its body jerked through the snow rather than gliding as he would have expected.

The man swung his blade to keep the creature at bay. It stood its tallest, casting its hulking shadow over him, and he knew this was the opportunity he had been waiting for. He reached for the now glowing dagger and threw it with force, hitting just beneath the creature's chin. It let out a shrill roar of pain as it began to flail its head wildly. The dagger had managed to pierce the hide of the beast but he did not understand why the creature reacted in such a way. He had merely wished to use the dagger as a distraction. He rushed forward, using his momentum to launch himself at the wyrm. With both hands, the man plunged the broadsword into the beast's smooth crest. He felt every part of the skin as the blade slowly tore into flesh. Warm blood sprayed, and the sword continued to burn bright green as the wyrm shrieked and jerked in the crimson snow.

As the wyrm's jerking stopped and its cries of pain became silent, the man noticed that his sword's flames extinguished. The beast was dead.

He made his way towards its head and removed the dagger, placing it into his belt. Something was not right with this creature. Before he had awoken in this snowy landscape, the voice had warned him that there was a darkness coming.

Was this the darkness that the voice had been talking about? Returning his broadsword to the scabbard on his back, the man made his way through the snow once more.

He needed a bath. But more than anything, he wanted to get some distance between him and the dead wyrm before its mother turned up.

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CHAPTER
FOUR

It was another two days of arduous walking before the man finally reached a small village. The only place he was interested in was an inn so he could get himself cleaned up and sink some ale.

When he walked into town, there was no one around. Small houses littered the sides, each covered in a dusting of snow. The fenced fields behind the houses implied that this was a farming village ripe with trade, which made Gregor feel encouraged. If he was on a trading route, he could better orient himself.

It didn't take the man long to find where everyone was. They were huddled together in the centre of the square around someone. As he drew closer, he could hear raised voices, but there was too much of a ruckus for him to make out exactly what they were saying, so he moved closer to find out.

"What did the boy see?" a male voice called out with a broad accent.

A panicked woman demanded, "What did this?"

"What if it comes back?"

Standing at the back of the crowd, the aged man could see clearly over the tops of the gathered townspeople as he searched for what had gotten this crowd in such a frenzy.

"This has never happened in Garuvia before," a woman's voice called back to the crowd. She addressed everyone as she spoke, stepping onto the well behind her to better project her voice. "Right now, we do not know what creature has done this." The woman stood tall with the confident posture of someone who had earned stature within the village. She wore a

yakula fur-lined coat, its hood drawn over her head to protect her from the cold.

“Has the boy spoken to anyone?” a man asked with frustration.

“He won’t.” The woman’s face became drawn. “Whatever it is that the boy has seen, it has left him a mumbling mess. Nothing he says is making sense.”

“We need to know what has done this, we need to find it and kill it!”

“Yeah!” parts of the crowd roared.

“The boy needs to gather himself and tell us what happened, what has done this.”

As he observed, the man couldn’t help but think that there was more to this than was apparent. It also appeared that whatever the woman’s role in this village was, she was being challenged.

“Colt has just seen his parents slaughtered just a few hours ago. His sisters are missing. He needs time to process what has happened. Right now, he needs compassion, not an interrogation,” the woman explained.

For some reason the mention of the missing girls resonated with him. Something that he couldn’t place his finger on. It was as though his heart ached for something but he could not fathom what it was.

The crowd heeded the woman’s words. Even the agitated man seemed to be nodding with approval.

“Put increased numbers on watch tonight, in case whatever attacked this family returns,” she commanded.

“I’ll lead a patrol to see if we can find any signs of it.” The man who had been calling out stepped forward and turned to face the crowd, his long dark hair and thick black beard on display. “Does anyone volunteer?”

Half a dozen men and women stepped forward, also wearing yakula fur-lined coats. For some reason, the aged man knew that this was a high-quality fur used to protect from the cold, and wondered if this was a remnant from his past life, or knowledge bestowed upon him by the mysterious god.

“Thank you, Theus. Do not search too far, and listen out for the bells in case the creature returns.” The woman offered her hand in appreciation and they gripped one another’s forearms. The group of men and woman moved together and walked back down the frosted road in the direction that he had just come from.

Theus cast his eyes over the aged man as he walked past and stopped in his tracks. “Who are you?” he asked.

“Just passing through.” The aged man’s gruff voice cracked as he spoke words for the first time.

Theus looked him over for a moment, an untrusting expression on his face. “I find it odd that a family is slaughtered and a stranger turns up covered in blood.” There was an accusatory tone to Theus’s voice that the man did not appreciate.

“I assure you I have just walked those frozen plains for multiple days. I was not here when this happened. Besides, it would be suspect of me to stay around, had I committed a murder. It is not human blood that stains my clothes.” It was a partial lie, but how could he explain that he had been brought back from death after being murdered himself? “That in mind, do you happen to know where I can find the inn? I am in need of warm water to clean myself and my clothes.”

“The tavern is just beyond the well there,” Theus offered uncertainly. “The villagers will keep a close eye on you.”

“They can look all they want.” The aged man had no intention of hanging around once he’d gotten what he came for.

Theus huffed in disapproval but it seemed he had bigger things to deal with, and he left to follow the patrol.

The crowd around the well began to disperse, revealing a small pathway which sat just behind it. Following Theus’s directions, the man headed towards the tavern, all the while listening to the people gossip about their own theories for what had happened to Colt’s family last night. The frozen floor underfoot crunched under each step that he took. The streets were covered in some form of ground stone, which prevented the surface from becoming slippery when walking. Realising he stood taller than most in the village, the aged man could not help but notice the untrusting eyes that continued to follow him as he walked.

It didn’t take long to reach the end of the path and find the tavern. A faded sign hung just above the door that read ‘The Red Dragon’ over a painting of a dragon sitting at a table. The name made the man smile to himself as he stepped inside.

The small handful of people drew quiet as they looked to the door where the tall stranger stood. Eyes burned into him as locals whispered to one another.

“It could be him.”

“He’s covered in blood, what if it’s him that did this?”

“He wouldn’t be that brazen!”

They spoke as though he was unable to hear them, and he knew he should make haste; it wouldn’t be long before the villagers arrived with pitchforks, accusing him of murder. He did not blame them. They were right to question his presence here. He was questioning it himself.

As he walked towards a barmaid who was cleaning one of the tables, Gregor’s feet left dusted footsteps on the dark wood floor.

“Can I help you?” Her broad accent was similar to Theus’s, further highlighting how far north he was. “Not being funny, sir, but you look like shit.”

“I am in need of a bath and clean clothes,” he said.

The barmaid cast him a smile and moved towards the bar. “Well that’s what we are here for. I will fetch a bath for you upstairs. I assume you have coin, sir?”

The man searched his pocket and removed a small bag which contained just a few gold coins. “Will one of these do?”

The barmaid drew a confused expression as she picked up one of the coins. After looking it over, she placed it against her lips and bit down on it. “Never seen a coin like this before, it definitely is a gold coin though. Why don’t you have a drink whilst you are waiting for your bath.” She grabbed hold of a large bottle behind her and poured him a drink, placing it on the bar in front of him. “Given the look of you, I think you need something stronger than ale. This is made from the ice taken from the top of the Glegarian mountains. Tell me, what’s your name, stranger?”

That was a question he had been asking himself for the last few days. No matter how hard he tried to remember, he had no idea who he was. He stumbled for words for a moment before a thought entered his mind. A name, on the tip of his tongue.

“Gregor.” He spoke the words slowly, unsure. “My name is Gregor.” He didn’t know where he plucked this from, but he was as sure as the snow outside that it was his to own. His memory had done him a favour in this instance and returned. As if dragged from the darkness, the knowledge of his name had forced itself to the forefront of his mind. If his name could come back to him, perhaps the rest of his forgotten memories could, too.

“If you say so, Gregor. Welcome to The Red Dragon. Go and sit by the fire whilst I run that bath for you. Don’t sit too close to the others, though. Not to be rude or anything, but your smell is enough to scare off many a man or creature.”

Gregor hadn’t really noticed whilst out in the frozen lands, the open air masking the horrendous musk he was carrying.

“You smell like death,” a woman’s voice called out from behind him.

Turning, Gregor recognised the woman who had been addressing the village earlier. She lowered her hood, revealing short blond hair down to her shoulders. She had pale skin, her cheeks reddened by the cold air outside.

“Morning, Thodana, there’s a hot brew by the fire for you,” the barmaid said as she made to leave.

“Thanks, Jura.” Thodana headed towards the hot brew that had been prepared for her. “Do you care to join me?”

Gregor nodded, taking a sip of the spirit. It burned his throat as he swallowed, an explosion of sharp flavour engulfing his tongue as he felt his cheeks sting. The potent drink was exactly what he needed right now. He brushed his thick grey hair from his face and joined Thodana at her table. She wrapped both hands around her brew whilst letting the fire kiss her legs.

Gregor sunk into the chair opposite her and was taken aback by the comfort of it. He hadn’t realised just how stiff his back was until it cracked louder than the burning embers in the fire. Gregor let out a sigh before taking another sip of the Glegarian spirit. For a few moments after, the air he breathed felt fresh and clear as his mouth tingled from the drink.

Though he appreciated the respite from the harsh landscape, Gregor didn’t want to stay here any longer than necessary. More than anything, he wanted to learn more of his past. Despite what he had been told by his resurrector, remembering his name had pushed this goal to the forefront, and now it gnawed away at him like an itch that he was unable to scratch. Gregor wasn’t in the mood to be dragged into small talk, as he didn’t see how this would aid his quest.

“Tell me, Gregor, whose blood is it that you wear?” Thodana asked before taking a sip of her drink. Her eyes were drawn, her stress etched into her reddened cheeks. She came across as warm but seemed unsure of the stranger that she was speaking to.

Gregor looked down. The darkened blood had dried, but his clothes were saturated. “I was attacked by a frost wyrm.”

“How many men did you lose?”

“I was on my own.” Gregor took another sip of his drink and let out another sigh.

Thodana looked dumbfounded. “It would take at least eight of our villagers to trap one of those, more to kill it.”

“It was only a youngling. I moved on before its mother found me.”

“Still, you must have some power to be able to best such a creature. Tell me, how long do you plan on staying here, Gregor?” Thodana fixed him with her gaze.

Feeling uncomfortable with her looking at him as if he were some exotic animal on display, Gregor took another sip of his drink and stared into the fire to avoid eye contact. “Fight or die,” he said. “I chose to fight.”

“As you have probably heard, a creature slaughtered a family last night,” Thodana said. “Whatever it is, it is strong and unforgiving. I could do with someone like you helping me find and kill this beast.”

“And why should I help?” There was a shortness in his words that even Gregor did not expect. As he spoke, a strong, throbbing pain pulsated at the sides of his head, causing his eyes to water.

There is a darkness coming. Gregor’s mind went back to the voice that had woken him from his death. And the words repeated loudly around him, as crisp as the Glegarian spirit he drank. Startled, Gregor looked around the room for the source of the voice, but judging by everyone else’s lack of reaction, he seemed to be the only one who could hear it.

“I fear there is more at play here than meets the eye. What if whatever has done this comes back?” Thodana was desperate, her eyes darting from one side to the other as she pleaded with Gregor.

Was this the darkness that he had been told to search for? Intrigued, Gregor finished the last of his drink and savoured the sharpness it brought to his mouth. Once more he held a curiosity about the missing girls, a deep longing to know more. He wondered if in helping find the girls, it would help him with his memories. After all, it was when he heard about them that he felt something stir within. Something long forgotten, a memory just sitting on the outer edge of the darkness.

“Just come and explore the house with me. After that, you are free to leave.”

“I suppose I can have a look,” he said, staring into his glass. His headache subsided as soon as he agreed to help.

“I will pay for your lodgings here. We could use more people like you in Garuvia.” Thodana seemed to gain a second wind as she finished her own drink. “Get yourself cleaned up, then I will take you to Horus’s farm where the creature attacked. I will wait down here for you.”

With this, Gregor stood.

“Hopefully we can find some clues at the house,” Thodana told him.

Maybe, thought Gregor, they would find some clues about his past.

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CHAPTER
FIVE

The bath was not as relaxing as Gregor had imagined it would be, but he enjoyed it nonetheless after being frozen in ice for a time no one knew. The warmth of the water thawed him out, but he felt an urgency about cleaning himself up given that Thodana was waiting for him downstairs. The barmaid, Jura, had laid out a fresh cloth black shirt and dark pants. His leather boots were still wearable, as was his belt and scabbard. Jura had also left a white yakula fur-lined coat, which Gregor now realised everyone in the village wore to protect them from the cold. Little did they know that he was unfazed by the low frigid temperature, but he still appreciated the comfort of warmth. After placing his scabbard and sword over his shoulder and in place on his back, Gregor ran his hands through his wet hair and slicked it back out of his face. He stared at himself in the mirror on the wall. A stranger's face and eyes greeted him, someone he did not know yet whose body and mind he inhabited. His hair was dark grey, long and thick. His piercing blue eyes had brown speckles in them that marbled like flashes of stone frozen in ice. His full grey beard hid his chiselled jawline, and deep wrinkles etched across his forehead, the side of his eyes appearing cracked with age. He looked like a man that had reached his late fifties, maybe even sixty, but his physique resembled that of someone younger in years. His body didn't stoop like that of an old man, and he stood tall with broad shoulders and a powerful frame. Taking one last look at the stranger in front of him, Gregor let out a sigh before heading for the door to meet Thodana. When he re-entered the tavern, she was leaning against the bar, discussing something with Jura.

“Ah, he’s here.” Thodana straightened and dusted crumbs off her jacket, the remainder of her breakfast.

Gregor reached Thodana and opened the door. “Shall we?”

She led the way outside and the two of them made their way through the village to the farm where the slaughter had taken place.

“Where were you heading before you came here?” Thodana asked as they walked.

“Nowhere specific,” Gregor answered. He was a nomad, he had no home. No direction, just a message from some unknown deity to rid the world of darkness. Something he did not want to share with someone he had only just met.

“Feeling talkative, then.”

They continued through the hustle and bustle of the village, and Gregor couldn’t help but find it strange that normality had resumed so quickly despite what had happened at the farm.

“What time did it happen?” he asked.

“Oh, you’re ready to talk now?” Thodana smirked. “Just after dusk. The sun had not been set long before the screams were heard.”

“Whose screams?”

“Gleya’s. By the time Theus arrived, she and her husband had already been slaughtered. He is the one who found Colt.”

“Theus? That was the man who led the patrol earlier.”

“You are inquisitive, aren’t you? I knew you would be right for the job.” Thodana was unable to hide her delight. “Theus heard the screams and ran to help, but by the time he got there, it was too late, and Colt’s sisters were gone.”

“Hmmm,” Gregor grumbled as they continued their walk. They passed a market vendor trading fish, the smell knocking Gregor’s empty stomach. A group of children chased each other nearby tossing balls of snow at one another, laughing and cheering when one made contact. A stray snowball landed near Gregor’s feet, and when the children noticed him, their demeanours changed, their smiles lost in a single moment. Despite Gregor’s best attempts at a smile, the children scattered away from him, and Gregor felt the eyes of the rest of the village searing into him.

“He is a good man, Theus. Whatever did this, he would have fought it with his bare hands if he needed to,” Thodana continued, apparently not noticing the reactions to Gregor’s presence.

“He’s your brother, isn’t he?”

Thodana stopped in her tracks and turned to face Gregor. “How did you figure that out?”

“You felt the need to defend him before I said anything. And you have the same hair colour, and eyes.”

“Interesting.” Thodana turned and set off walking once more. “Come on, we are nearly there.” The powder snow crunched underfoot, the large clouds above warning that there was still more snow to come.

Theus had arrived first at the house, Gregor mused. This meant he must have been close by. Gregor felt that Theus’s name was already popping up too much, and given the reception he had given him when he first arrived, it did little to ease Gregor’s thoughts.

“Now, it’s not pretty inside,” Thodana told him when they reached the house. “Both Horus and Gleya’s bodies will be moved soon so we can bury them. This means we don’t have long to look around. We have never seen anything like this before.”

“What is your role in this village?” Gregor asked.

“I am the *ceann-cinnidh*.”

Gregor tried to repeat this back but failed miserably.

“Chieftain. I am the leader in Garuvia.”

“*Ceann-cinndh*,” he repeated slowly, the words sounding unnatural on his tongue.

Thodana opened the door and allowed for Gregor to enter, then followed him in and gagged instantly. She may have been the *ceann-cinnidh* but it seemed death like this was not something she had seen before. Blood was sprayed across the floor as if a bucket of Horus’s innards had been thrown across the room. His body lay flat by the overturned table, an expression of fear still apparent on his pale face. His wife, Gleya, sat slumped in a chair to the right, her throat slashed. Blood stained her clothes and arms where it had dripped into a congealed pool beneath her idle fingers. The odd drip splashed on the floor beneath her.

Thodana breathed in heavily and steadied herself. Gregor felt unfazed by the repugnant smell that greeted them. It had not been long since the slaughter, but the room already reeked of death and the decay had begun to set in. Gregor took a large breath of air through his nostrils and breathed out slowly before inhaling again. There was a light tinge in the air, one that he could faintly recognise, but he couldn’t put his finger on it.

He stepped towards Horus's body. The injury that killed him was apparent: he had a large hole in his chest, and his broken bones protruded from his flesh, his innards on display. Gregor knelt to inspect the wound.

"Something hit him with enough strength to send him from over there, to here." Gregor pointed to the spot where Thodana stood. "A claw used with such force would have carved him in half."

"What do you mean?"

"There is a faint smell in the air. Magic was used here. That rules out some creatures. The edges of this blow are burnt. Something cast either a flame enchantment or an energy blast." Gregor touched the edge of the wound where the charred texture confirmed this. "His wife, however . . ." Gregor moved across the room to where Gleya sat in the chair, and inspected her wound. There were clawed marks across either side of her throat, her skin jagged and torn.

"Whatever creature did this has ripped her throat out." Bloody footprints showed how she stumbled back into the chair before dying.

"Any idea what did this?" Thodana asked, kneeling over Horus to take another look at his wound.

"A chimera, possibly." Gregor did not know where he drew this information from, but his thoughts were instantly brought to the serpentine creature because it could cast fire magic. But could it have done this to the farmer's wife? "Maybe a jotunn." Jotunns walked on two feet, their usual ability to eat fire somehow manipulated. "I need to speak to the boy."

"He isn't talking sense at the moment. He needs rest."

Gregor stood tall. "If you want to have any hope of finding these girls, we need to speak to him now." As he made to leave, Thodana quickly followed.

"Gregor, he needs to rest."

"I need to speak to him."

"Fine. But remember what he has just been through. I fear his mind is so fragile that it runs the risk of breaking like glass if he is pressed too hard. He's at Fjora's house, just there." She pointed to a house across the street.

"You asked me to help. I will do what I must to get the answers you desire." Gregor marched across the street at pace and barged inside, not bothering to knock. "Where's the boy?" he demanded. The bluntness of his approach even surprised Gregor. It was not how he meant to come across, but he knew that the longer the search took, the bigger the risk for the

missing girls. His focus on them felt linked to a memory, one that he was desperate to unlock.

A portly woman sat by a young boy in front of an open fire. The boy's face was gaunt, his eyes empty and bereft of feeling as if he were merely a shell of the boy he once was.

"Who are you?" the woman demanded just as a man ran into the room, a knife clenched in his hand.

"We don't want any trouble here, get out of our house." The man stepped towards Gregor just as Thodana reached the house.

"You can't just barge into people's homes!" she scolded Gregor and raised her hands to the others. "Sorry, Gregor is helping me try and find whatever did this to poor Colt's family."

Gregor raised his hands to show he meant no harm. "Sorry, but I must speak to the boy." Gregor moved towards the boy and knelt before him. "What did you see, what did this?" Gregor planted his hands on the boy's shoulders and shook him as he spoke, an air of desperation around his actions that even he could not explain.

"Gregor!" Thodana roared.

"Thodana, explain yourself!" The man with the knife appeared ready to use it if he needed to.

"I need to know so we can find your sisters," Gregor continued, ignoring the others. "Do you understand that? Do you understand I am here to help?"

The boy's eyes met his own and he stared deeply into them for a moment. "Its eyes, its eyes." Colt sprang to life, repeating the words over and over.

"What do you mean, boy?" Gregor continued to hold onto Colt, but the boy's presentation was getting increasingly agitated.

"Thodana, stop this madness," Fjora wailed.

"The—the glow, the glow, the eyes, the eyes." Colt rocked back and forth. "Purple, glowing eyes."

Gregor let go of him in an instant and ran from the house, nearly knocking Thodana over in the process. His pace was quick for a man of his size and supposed age, and within a moment he was bursting through the door of the farmhouse once more. Rushing up the stairs, he began flinging doors open as he searched each of the bedrooms until he eventually found

the room where the sisters slept. Small beds sat at each side of the room, the names of the children carved into the wooden footboards.

A pang of pain crept into Gregor's chest as though he had lost something. An echo of his former life crept to the forefront of his mind, but it remained distant enough that he couldn't see. A memory on the far edge of a shadow, out of sight and too far for him to reach. The empty beds resonated with Gregor on a level that he did not understand, and he had an overwhelming urge to find the girls, to make sure they were safe. The paternal instinct was overpowering at worst and overwhelming at best.

If he could find them, he was certain he would get a piece of his former life back, somehow.

His heart raced. For some reason unbeknown to him, Gregor knew what he was dealing with. As he stepped farther into the room, a light hum began to emanate from the broadsword strapped to his back. Then he noticed it in his pocket. Reaching in, he removed the dagger he had whittled, which had begun to glow emerald green.

The creature was still here.

The hum in the dagger got stronger with each step that he took. When he reached the foot of the girls' beds, the light from the weapons illuminated the room, and Gregor's eyes were drawn to something in the corner of the ceiling. A set of glowing purple eyes greeted him, the body of the creature masked by some form of magic. A loud shriek pierced Gregor's ears as the creature made its presence known. The eyes moved towards him, and Gregor reached out, hoping to grab it before it reached him. The dagger emitted an energy that knocked the creature back towards the wall, and Gregor seized the opportunity to launch himself at it. Removing his sword at the same time, he pressed the creature against the wall, all the while the magic from his broadsword forcing the creature to reveal its form. The magic masking slowly peeled back from the creature's face to reveal row upon row of jagged, snapping teeth. Its large, glowing eyes were feral in the way they darted around the room, as if it were not Gregor that it wanted. Its scrawny body was disjointed, its arms and legs able to bend unnaturally. Its bones snapped and cracked as its limbs frantically clawed at Gregor, who stood firm against the spectral creature.

"I see you!" Gregor snarled. Its movement became more disjointed, more frantic. He slowly rolled his broadsword from its flat edge onto its side and pressed his blade into the creature's chest. A foul, burning smell

filled the room as Gregor's weapon singed the creature's body. A shrill scream of agonising pain left its mouth, its snapping jaws not stopping until Gregor felt the crunch of bones and the thud of the wall as the blade cut through the vile creature.

The weapon's glow began to fade, and the room darkened. The beast was dead. Treacle-like blood dripped from the broadsword, and the creature dropped to the floor, then began to disintegrate. Gregor knelt to pick up the wooden dagger and placed it in his pocket. The embers surrounding the creature left nothing but ash under his feet.

"What the fuck was that!"

Gregor turned to see Thodana standing open-mouthed in the doorway of the bedroom.

"It was a dybukk, Thodana." Gregor stepped away from the ashes around him, patrolling the room to see if his weapons would emit any more energy.

A thought entered his mind and he felt it was fated for him to be present in this village, in this moment. Whoever it was that resurrected him from the dead had tasked him with vanquishing the darkness. He was sure of it, as sure as the curse that had been placed on him. He needed to find the sisters and he needed to find those responsible for this. He felt certain that doing so might just help him unlock the mysteries of his past.

Gregor turned to face Thodana whilst sheathing his sword. "Someone has cursed this family."

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CHAPTER
SIX

"What is a dybukk?" Thodana leant against the Horus's farmhouse, her skin a ghostly shade.

Gregor stood beside her, musing over his thoughts. "A dybukk is the spirit of someone departed of this world. Their souls become corrupted and warped over time. In some circumstances, they can become so corrupted that they take the form of the thing you have just seen."

"Why, though? Why would they attack Horus and his family?"

"That is what we don't know, but now we know that someone here has summoned them. Dybukks can only be summoned to exact a purpose, and they can only be released by the magic that binds them once their goal has been achieved. They are vengeful, parasitic creatures that possess their hosts, taking control of their bodies and minds. If the dybukk takes possession of a body for too long, the host's flesh and bones begin to deteriorate."

Beside the house a large herd of animals were bunched together for warmth. They were tall, four-legged creatures, standing not too much smaller than a steed. Long white fur covered their bodies, draping down from their necks all the way down to the ground. Some of the majestic creatures had large swirling antlers protruding out of the front of their heads. Gregor couldn't put his finger on what the creatures were, which was strange given that he seemed to have a vast catalogue of creatures and demons in his mind.

"Those are Horus's yakulas. They provide the warm fur that lines all of our coats. It's what makes us able to survive out here in these harsh lands.

The fur is highly sought after.”

“So there is our potential motive,” Gregor said. He continued to stare at the yakulas as they grazed on what grass and leaves they could. As he watched, the herd shuffled along, and to Gregor’s surprise, a large patch of thawed grass remained where they had been standing.

“As you can see, their fur generates a lot of heat. It’s why they bunch up together. Quite clever, really.” Thodana looked Gregor over. “Your coat is covered in blood again. Maybe a darker colour would have been better for you.” She smiled at Gregor but he remained stony faced.

“It will wash,” he said.

“Maybe, but you won’t get blood out of that coat.”

“Do you want me to help you find this monster or do you want to talk about my coat?”

Thodana’s expression changed from light-hearted to perplexed. “I saw you kill the dybukk with my own eyes.”

“What do you think took the girls?”

“You think the dybukk took them?”

“Remember when I said dybukks possess their hosts? I think the remaining one was for the boy, that’s why it stayed in the house. It couldn’t leave until it had possessed him. As it had been summoned and commanded to do so.”

Gregor hopped over the fence and into the field where the yakulas grazed. They lifted their heads, alert to a stranger’s presence. They began moving away from Gregor and Thodana towards the far side of the field.

“They are scared of their own shadows,” said Thodana. “That said, don’t get too close, Gregor. They can be nasty little bastards if they feel threatened. Don’t want to end up with one of them antlers up your arse. What is it you’re looking for?”

“Proof that the girls are still alive.” Gregor travelled to the rear of the farmhouse and stopped as he reached the back door. “How much snow fell here during the night?”

“It wasn’t heavy. About the depth of a book. Why?”

“See those tracks there?” Gregor pointed to a patch of grass that remained uncovered by the snow. “The yakulas were here when the attack happened. Then they ran that way.” The small U-shaped hoof prints were dug into the snow erratically as the herd had moved from its initial spot.

Gregor inspected the snow. “Except those are not yakula prints.” Something had moved in the opposite direction of the herd.

Two sets of children’s footprints moved through the snow towards the corner of the field. “They went that way.”

Gregor picked up the pace as he followed the girls’ footprints, his boots crunching into the untrodden ice.

“Gregor, we need to be careful. Looking at those clouds, a snowstorm could be on its way.”

They reached the corner of the fence and, upon inspection, Gregor could see that the girls had climbed over and continued their walk. He placed his hand on the fence and vaulted it.

“What lies that way?” He pointed out into the vast, white land.

“Farther north, nothing but rock faces and mountains.”

“There isn’t any time to lose. Not if you want to see those girls alive again. Are you coming, Thodana?”

“Gregor, those clouds tell me a snowstorm is brewing. It would be madness to head straight out.”

“If we wait around we’ll lose these tracks and have even less of a chance of finding them.” Gregor turned and began walking through the snow, following the tracks closely. There was a purpose to this, a reason the dybukk had possessed them and walked this way. They needed to find them before it was too late.

Thodana followed but Gregor continued at a pace that caused her to fall behind, all the while his gaze fixed upon the tracks.

“Gregor, at least let me keep up with you,” Thodana called. “If we carry on like this, they’ll need to send out a party to find us, too. Those clouds look as though they’re ready to bring in a drift. If we get caught in that without our effects, we’ll be dead by the time they find us.”

Gregor stopped his march for a moment and weighed his options. “How far is it until we hit the rock face?”

Thodana caught up to him, placing her hands on her hips as she gathered her breath. “About half a day’s walk, if we walk without a break.”

Gregor knew that the coldness of the snow did not appear to affect him, in no small part due to the newfound magic that coursed through his blood. Thodana, on the other hand, was susceptible to the cold. “You should turn back. I can carry on from here.”

“And how will you find your way back? I’m coming with you. That storm will hit us in a few hours if we’re lucky, sooner if we’re not.”

Gregor stared into the darkening skies ahead of them, the skyline like waters on a stormy sea.

“There is a way to move faster across the snow, but I’ll need to go back to the village.”

“Thodana, we don’t have time to wait around.”

“You carry on following the tracks. I will catch you up.” Thodana turned and began to run back down to the farmhouse, quickly vaulting the fence and making her way back into the village.

Gregor let out a large sigh before turning and searching the snow for the possessed children’s footprints. As he followed them, the snow gradually got deeper and deeper until eventually it reached the top of his boots. His pace now slowed, he found himself having to take larger steps each time, heaving his boots out of the snow in order to move forward. Strangely, the girls’ footprints did not sink as deep down as Gregor’s. Had being possessed affected how they moved through the snow?

One thing was clear: at this rate, their movement would be far quicker than his own. Nonetheless, he carried on through the powdered snow, undeterred by the potential threats ahead of him.

A darkness is coming. With little else to go off, Gregor could only assume he was doing the right thing. That he was walking the right path. Saving two girls possessed by demons must surely be an act that the gods would favour.

He had no idea how much time had passed, but by the time the snow reached his waist, there was no way to move farther forward, and he was forced to stop. The packed snow proved near impossible to traverse, and in this moment a sense of vulnerability caught Gregor off guard. With nothing but his thoughts to keep him company, Gregor feared that in his haste he had created a situation where he could find himself encased in ice. A fear overcame him that he wasn’t expecting, memories of a sword being buried into his stomach. For a moment he could swear he felt the pain of his once mortal wound re-opening, and a sense of panic coursed through him. His breathing elevated as he relived his re-awakening and the pain that came with thawing out. He didn’t want to relive that excruciating moment again. Now would be a good time for his sword to light up with flames and melt the snow he was trapped in, but he knew he could not do that on demand.

In the distance behind him, he could hear something approaching, and he readied himself. He searched the skies and cursed the gods, his mind warning them that this best not be the mother of the frost wyrm he had crossed paths with just a couple of days earlier.

Gregor turned his head and focused on the ever-increasing wind, listening intently. A light jingling noise caught his attention, and he searched his mind for what beast could make such a sound.

It didn't take long, however, for this to become clearer. Thodana appeared, sitting atop a sled being pulled by yakulas. As she pulled up next to him, he couldn't help but smile at her.

"Maybe I should have listened to you," he told her.

"Maybe you should have, given this being my home. I know the weather and the snow better than you ever will." Thodana let out a smug laugh. "Wonder how much longer you would have lasted."

"Are you going to help me, or just mock me all day?" Gregor reached out his hands.

"You're too heavy for me," she said. "Here, grab hold of this." She threw some rope towards Gregor, which he grabbed tightly. "Yah!" She whipped the yakulas, who set off at speed.

Gregor felt pressure against his chest as the yakulas dragged him deeper into the snow, and as it packed down, he was pulled towards the surface. He was impressed by how easily Thodana had gotten him out of his predicament.

"Don't move, you will sink back down if you do." Thodana steered the yakulas and looped around until she drew level with Gregor. Gregor accepted her offered hand and rolled onto the back of the sled, grateful for her assistance.

"So, they're not just used for their fur then. They really are a valuable creature to have." Gregor climbed up to his feet, standing far taller than Thodana.

"Here, take the reins."

Gregor accepted them tentatively.

"Ever rode on a sled before?"

"Can't say I have." Gregor smiled. He had no idea if he had or hadn't. "Why are you giving these to me?"

"Because you're more likely to pull me backwards, look at the size of you. I'll hold on to you, I can still help steer the yakulas and make sure

we're heading in the right direction."

Gregor gripped the reins tightly as Thodana shuffled behind him and wrapped her arms around him, grabbing hold of his coat. "Yah!" He whipped at the reins and the yakulas set off at once. The force caused Gregor to jerk backwards but he was able to steady himself as their sled began moving over the snow. The cold breeze pressed against his face, and he needed to squint against the light snow that began to fall.

Gregor was alarmed at how exhilarating it felt to be moving at such speed, and he was hopeful that they would be able to find the girls more quickly. The mountains didn't feel too far away now, and with the missing girls on foot, they could maybe claw back some much-needed time.

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CHAPTER
SEVEN

Even though moving at speed, Gregor quickly got the hang of steering the yakulas, and he kept his sights on the girls' tracks. They had been riding for a few hours, and a large, black rock face was visible now not too far away from them.

Looking up at the sun, Gregor realised that in a moment it would fall behind the mountains and the temperature would plummet even further. This wouldn't faze him, but he was more concerned about Thodana's wellbeing. Almost the second the sun vanished, the wind seemed to pick up, and although the warmth wasn't noticeable when the sun was up, it was certainly noticeable when it was missing. Thodana's grip around Gregor's side tightened as she started to take warmth from him.

The footprints led all the way to the rock face before turning to run parallel to it. Gregor steered the yakulas and slowed the pace down, knowing they were close. There had to be a cave somewhere along here. When the footprints stopped, Gregor knew they had found what they were searching for and pulled tightly on the reins, bringing the yakulas to a halt.

"They're in there." Gregor pointed at the small opening, barely visible and camouflaged in the jet-black rocks. He jumped from the sled to find that the snow was not as deep as where Thodana had rescued him, and he offered his hand to assist Thodana.

Smirking at him, Thodana knocked his hand away and jumped from the sled of her own accord before starting to trudge through the powdered snow towards the cave's opening. Gregor followed her inside.

As they entered, Gregor felt a slight vibration in his pocket, and he removed the wooden dagger which had begun to glow a soft green.

“Here, take this.” He passed it to Thodana who held it out in front of her, its pulsating glow lighting the cave in front of her. Gregor unsheathed his broadsword which had also started glowing. “We are definitely in the right place. They are close.”

“How do you know?” Thodana asked, focusing on the black void beyond their periphery.

“The magic in my blade, the flames that it can emit. It gets stronger when we are closer to darkness, to demons.”

“Just who are you, Gregor? Where do you come from?” Thodana’s words skipped down the darkened cave like a stone skimming water.

“I couldn’t tell you.” Gregor thought an honest approach was best.

The two of them continued down the cave until they reached a large opening, illuminating it with the plume of emerald-green light. Aside from the trickle of water pushing its way through the rocks, the cave was quiet. And then, Gregor heard a scratching noise.

“Stop.” Gregor held one of his arms out to block Thodana’s path. “I hear something.”

Thodana turned her head and listened intently.

“They are close.” He took a step towards the patch of darkness, entering the large chasm. Gregor could only hear the faint noise, but he was sure of what it was. Stepping slowly towards the centre, he scanned around them for signs of the girls. “They know we’re here, they are in this room.”

The scratching got louder, a clearer sound of something scurrying across the stone. In front of them, to the side of them. Gregor was taken aback by how fast they were able to move. His head shifted from left to right and back again as he desperately tried to follow the sound of their movement.

“What are they trying to do?” Thodana asked, clasping the small wooden dagger in front of her.

The noise grew louder. Gregor and Thodana moved back-to-back and slowly moved in a circle as they waved their makeshift torches, attempting to gain any glimpse of the girls. It was to no avail. Each time Gregor thought they might be close enough to see, they moved out of sight. The problem they had now was that they were both sitting ducks.

As soon as the scurrying noise became audible, it stopped.

“What are they doing?” Thodana asked, her voice elevated.

“They don’t want us here.”

The light from Thodana's dagger shined over the contorted faces of one of the girls.

"Thodana!"

By the time Thodana saw her, it was too late. A clicking noise left the girl's mouth, and she shrieked as she jumped on Thodana, pulling her to the ground. Gregor grabbed the back of the possessed girl's clothes and dragged her off, hurtling the demon away from her.

"Be careful, we don't want to hurt the girls!" Thodana got back to her feet, her glowing dagger a few paces away from her. The ray of light caught two sets of eyes which were fixed firmly on Gregor and Thodana, a bug-like clicking noise coming from them. Either the two of them were communicating or they were angry and ready to attack. Gregor shifted himself, unsure of what to do. Swinging his sword would ultimately slay the demon but likely the girls, too.

The demons jumped, one towards Thodana and the other towards Gregor. His broadsword burst into flames as the dybukk flung itself at him, shrieking with pain as the glow touched it. Not wanting to harm the girl, Gregor dropped the weapon and gripped the dybukk's outstretched arms, holding onto her wrists as tightly as he could. Sharp claws protruded from the ends of her bloodied fingers, frantically trying to claw at him. Her eyes were dark and sunken, and large, veined patches had formed around her eyes, which were not visible. Rows of razor-sharp teeth filled the girl's mouth.

No child should have to go through this.

Thodana lay on the ground, trying her hardest to fend off the other dybukk. It sat over her, feverishly clawing into her chest as Thodana tried to evade the blows. Its limbs moved unnaturally, bones cracking as it used its host to try and kill Thodana at any cost.

The one Gregor was holding kicked out against his chest, causing him to stumble backwards, but he was able to keep his footing and he tightened his grip on the demon.

"They're too far gone!" he exclaimed. It was the conclusion he had feared. He knew in his heart by the way the girls' bones had been broken, the way those teeth protruded from their mouths, the way those claws forced their way out of their fingertips. Even if they were able to stop the dybukks, the girls' bodies would likely not survive the transition back from possession.

“We have to try, Gregor.” A clawed hand raked across Thodana’s cheek, tearing her flesh as though it were paper. Blood splattered across the floor, and the dybukk seized its opportunity to aim a bite at Thodana’s neck. Gregor spun towards it, using his weight to gather momentum before throwing the dybukk at the demon atop Thodana. It clattered into it with tremendous force, and the two of them wailed and shrieked in pain.

“Thodana!” Gregor pulled her to her feet. She clasped her hand to the gaping wound on her face, her blood oozing between the gaps in her fingers.

“What now, Gregor?”

“We need to get the dybukks from their bodies either way.” One of them reached from the darkness for Gregor and took a swipe at him, but Gregor dodged this and grabbed hold of its wrist. Its claws embedded into his forearm, causing him to grimace. He pulled it towards him and out of the shadows. As it approached, he smashed his hilt into the side of its face as hard as he could, slamming it into the ground with a thud. Then he turned his broadsword sideways, launching himself into the darkness. The flames grew their brightest as he connected with the other dybukk, pinning it to the wall. Its blood-curdling shrieks echoed around the cavern as it squirmed in a frenzy to release itself from Gregor’s grip. It couldn’t, though, and its skin sizzled and popped from the flames.

“Gregor, you’re going to kill her!”

“There’s no other way!” he barked, pushing the flat side of the blade against the demon.

The dybukk continued to shriek, and the one he had knocked to the floor began to drag itself back to its feet. Gregor knew he did not have much longer. He gave one last heave as he continued to press against the demon’s body. Its shriek grew louder, and blood began to trickle from Gregor’s ears, but he did not stop, pushing through the pain from the noise. The girl’s neck cracked straight from its stooped angle. The dybukk couldn’t take the pain any longer and forced itself from the girl’s body, separating.

“Catch her!” Gregor commanded as he stepped from the wall and released the girl’s body.

Thodana lunged forward as the girl collapsed in a heap, preventing her from smashing her head against the rocks. “It’s okay, I’ve got you.”

Thodana wrapped her arms around her and slumped against the wall beside her.

The separated demon made to leave, but Gregor sliced his broadsword down the back of the dybukk, cleaving it in two. As its body began to turn to ash, Gregor spun once more and dived onto the remaining demon before it could fully get back to its feet, pinning it face-down with his sword. It too began shrieking and squirming, its bones snapping and cracking as sparks drew from the rock where it tried to claw itself free. The skin of its host sizzled as Gregor's weapon seared its flesh. When the dybukk had had enough, it released the girl from its grasp and made to attack. Gregor sprang to his feet and brought down his flaming broadsword, quickly removing the demon's head from its body in a single blow. The warm blood sprayed over Thodana and the girl she held, clinging to them.

Dropping to his knees, Gregor placed his ear over the lips of the girl he had just released, and waited until she let out a shallow breath.

"She's alive, but only just."

"This one is the same." Thodana sat rocking the girl, and Gregor wondered if it was herself or the child that she was reassuring. "Gregor, we need to get them back quickly, there is a healer in Garuvia who may be able to help."

The girls' bodies were bloodied and broken, and there were gaps where the sharp teeth had forced their way through their gums. Their fingers were ripped open and bloodied where the claws had been, but they were still alive, and that gave Gregor hope.

"Who would do this to a child, Gregor?" Thodana's eyes filled with tears.

Gregor couldn't answer. He scooped one of the girls up into his arms and carried her to exit the cave. Thodana picked up the other girl and they began to make their way back towards Thodana's sled.

The light from outside led their way back, and the dagger and sword's flames extinguished as they exited the cave.

"Thodana? Thodana, is that you?"

Thodana squinted. "Theus?" she asked, confused.

Thodana's brother stood at the cave entrance, blocking their path.

Gregor felt a surge of anger rip through him at the sight of the man. Theus was responsible for this. Why else would he be here? Consumed with untamed rage, Gregor charged up the passage towards him. It was an

unexpected primal anger, deep-rooted in his being. Gregor had disliked Theus from the start; there was something about him that had irked Gregor. His presence all but confirmed that he must have had something to do with these demons. Clenching his fist tightly, Gregor approached Theus, his face contorted with anger.

With a harsh crack, Gregor's fist met Theus's nose.

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CHAPTER
EIGHT

Theus's nose exploded on impact, turning the snow crimson in an instant. He fell backwards, almost disappearing into the deep snow.

"Where are the others you left with?" Gregor snarled. Despite carrying one of the girls over his shoulder, he was still able to act with vicious speed. "Why would you do this?" As Theus made to get up from the snow, Gregor stamped his foot into his chest, pushing him back down.

"Gregor!" Thodana cried, "We don't know that it was Theus!"

Theus tried to release himself from underneath Gregor's boot, but his strength paled in comparison to Gregor's. Gregor was charged with anger and fury.

"I haven't done anything!" Theus professed, wrapping his hands around Gregor's boot to lessen the pressure.

"Let him go, Gregor!"

"You're blinded by loyalty!" Gregor spoke with venom in his voice.

"And you are blinded by rage!"

"Honestly, I haven't done anything to these girls." Theus took a gulp of air. "I just this moment found the cave opening." He gasped for the breath that Gregor was restricting.

"How did you know your sister was in the cave?" Gregor pressed his boot down harder, his jaw clenched tightly. He could not abide anyone who could do this to a child.

"The—the sled," Theus stuttered. "I recognised Thodana's sled and the yakulas."

"Theus, where are the others that you set off with?" Thodana asked.

"You can't think I did this, sister, that I am capable of such an act?"

Gregor pressed his boot down harder still, pushing him as deep into the snow-filled ground as he could. If he pushed any harder, it was only a matter of time before he would hear the cracking of his ribs. “Your sister asked you a question.”

“They turned back, said it was madness to continue with a large snowstorm coming. I wanted to keep searching.”

“Gregor, lift up your boot,” Thodana demanded. “We do not know enough to tell if my brother is telling the truth or not.”

As much as it frustrated Gregor, he knew deep down that Thodana was right. “If I find you had anything to do with this, you’ll deal with a fate far worse than death.” He offered his threat through gritted teeth as he lifted his foot and moved for the sled. The storm hadn’t landed, but it was not far off now.

“We’re not all going to fit on that sled.” Thodana laid the girl down at the front of the sleigh and Gregor followed suit. They worked together to secure the unconscious twins.

“What happened to your face, Thodana?” Gregor could see that Theus was truly concerned about the gaping wound across Thodana’s face.

“I’ll be fine. We need to get these girls to the healer if they are to survive.”

“You should go, sister. Myself and your new friend can stay in this cave until the storm passes over.”

“There’s not a chance I am leaving you two together in a small space,” Thodana scoffed. “Gregor, you take the girls back on the sled. Our tracks here are still visible so you’ll be able to get back okay. We’ll remain here until the storm passes, then we will make our way back to the village. You need to move quickly. When you return, seek Igraine. She’ll be able to assist you.”

Gregor wanted to get Thodana to the healer, too, but he knew it was pointless to argue with Thodana, so he agreed to her plan without complaint. He didn’t know himself what he might do if he was left alone with her cowardly brother. He was sure in his heart that Theus had something to do with this whole mess. He stepped onto the sled and took hold of the reins, the unconscious girls strapped down in front of him.

“Go!” Thodana shouted.

“Yah!” The sled set off across the snow. Adrenaline coursed through Gregor’s veins as he steered the yakulas through the thick snow back

towards the village. The snow slowly started to drift in as the wind picked up and soon the storm began to rear its ugly head. The wind became fiercer still. If they got caught in the storm, it would further put the girls at risk, who were already desperately close to death.

The strength of the wind was almost enough to blow Gregor off the sled, but he held firm. His mind was filled with thoughts of confusion, frustration, and concern. Within a day of finding a village he had slain demons, found missing girls, and was now trying his hardest to escape an ensuing storm. He had even acquired a new name. Within a day he felt as though he had a new identity, a new purpose. With nothing to go off other than the voice he had spoken to before he was raised from the dead, he could only assume that he was walking the right path. He tried to focus his thoughts about his life before his rebirth, but again, drew nothing. His memories seemed to be encased in storm clouds thicker and far more dangerous than the ones that currently chased him.

“Yah, yah!” He whipped the yakulas again, who were beginning to tire. They had been running with little rest for most of the day. Gregor looked at the blackened sky above, clouded and haunted. Light vapours, green and yellow in colour, chased the skyline in replace of the stars. If not for the precarious circumstances, it would have been a sight to savour and enjoy. There was nothing in this situation that Gregor was enjoying.

“Is this what you want!” he roared to nothing, not knowing who exactly he was speaking to. “Is this how you are going to test me!” Screaming at the skies was doing nothing to help them speed up, but it did help him clear his mind. He whipped the yakulas again and they made a collective squealing noise. They sped up, and Gregor quickly wrapped the reins around his wrist to prevent from falling backwards into the snow. The hope Gregor had felt earlier faded like a dampening flame. They weren’t going to be able to outrun the storm. Was this a sign from the gods?

The storm was growing into a wild maelstrom, and snow pelted against his face, his hair frozen from the cold.

“Come on!” Gregor had resorted to begging the yakulas to get them to their destination. They seemed to have gained a second wind, and he was grateful for it.

Miraculously, Gregor could see the torches of Garuvia on the horizon, their flames a welcomed beacon. The yakulas gave one large push and they eventually dragged Gregor and the girls into the village. As the huts and

houses flew past, Gregor was startled to realise just exactly how fast they had been travelling.

“Woah!” Gregor pulled on the reins, and with a jerk, their pace slowed. The problem was, as the yakulas stopped, Gregor and the sled did not. They began to spin. Gregor let go of the reins and flung himself over the girls, fearful of the injuries they could sustain should they be thrown from the sled. As they spun out of control, Gregor lost sight of their surroundings, the huts becoming nothing but a darkened blur. He felt ready to heave from nausea. One thing he was quickly realising was that he did not like or welcome the dizzying feeling he was experiencing.

Suddenly the sled stopped, and snow cascaded over them as they hit a snow drift. The sled stooped, and though the girls were securely fastened into place, Gregor was not, and the force flung him through the snow. He bounced off the ground, and despite thickened snow falling, he felt each and every rock and stone that he ground over until eventually he stopped.

Ignoring his pain, he ran through the snow as fast as he could until he reached Shae and Freya. He hastily unfastened them and scooped them up, placing them one at a time over each of his shoulders.

The well where Thodana was addressing the crowd when he first arrived was encased in snow, but it gave him a marker for where he was. Gregor ran towards the alleyway that he knew led to The Red Dragon. The thick snow still made it hard to see, made worse by the darkness. He quickly saw the lights of the tavern and his heart skipped for a moment. He held no punches as he kicked the door open and burst inside.

The conversation in the room fell silent. The blustering storm whipped into the room, much to the annoyance of the group of men and women inside. Their frustrated expressions changed when they saw that Gregor was carrying the missing twins.

“Jura! I need Igraine, someone get me Igraine!”

He had done it. He had managed to get the girls back to Garuvia. Somehow in this moment they were still alive, despite everything that had happened. He just hoped they stayed that way.

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CHAPTER
NINE

Jura recoiled in horror when she saw the aftermath of Freya and Shae's possession. She led Gregor to a vacant room with a bed large enough to fit both girls, and he delicately laid them side by side. They were hardly breathing, and Jura sent one of the villagers to find Igraine at once. When Igraine arrived a short while later, she ushered Gregor out of the room. The girls' pale, gaunt faces seared into his memories, something that he would probably never forget.

The tavern's atmosphere had diminished into nothing more than hushed, whispered words. The embers of the fire snapped and cracked louder than any conversation taking place this evening.

Gregor leant against the bar with his hands pressed against his head, trying in vain to relieve his headache. He grabbed the bottle of the spirit Jura had given him earlier. He needed something to help him forget, wanted to make his mind numb to what he had witnessed. As he poured himself a glass, his eyes met the gaze of a man wearing a thick yakula fur hat, who simply nodded at him, as if the man was giving him his approval in Jura's absence. Without a moment's hesitation, Gregor imbibed the glass in one go. The crisp, sharp spirit burned all the way down his throat until it reached his stomach where it continued to warm him. Slamming the glass down, he poured himself another until the glass was about two-thirds full, and drank.

If it was not Theus, who would do this unspeakable act? Theus turning up just as they were leaving the cave couldn't have been a coincidence. Gregor had alarmed himself at how fast he was to anger and lash out at Thodana's brother.

Freya and Shae were so badly damaged, it would take a favour from the gods for them to make it at this stage. *A darkness is coming*. If it was the gods that raised him from the dead, why would they not give him more information, more detail for the tasks they wanted him to do? Gregor knew his strength and stamina were more than that of an average man. He had a broadsword that could command flames through magic. His mind was a codex of information on monsters and demons—so why did he still feel so in the dark?

Frustrated, Gregor finished the Glegarian spirit and slammed his glass onto the bar. The noise caused the room to fall even more silent than it already was.

"'Scuse me, sir." A broad yet timid voice caught Gregor's attention to his side. It was the man with the yakula fur hat. He studied Gregor through narrow browns eyes set in a worn, wrinkled face.

"I just wanted to say thanks. If not for you, those girls would still be lost to whatever it was that took them." He patted Gregor on the arm and raised his ale. "These lands need more people like you."

"I appreciate your words, but I cannot take praise whilst I do not know if those girls have survived."

"Humble as well. The names Morath, by the way. In case you was wondering."

"Gregor," he said back.

"Where do you hail from, Gregor? I am born and bred in this very village. Never really explored more than a few miles beyond the boundaries. Never needed to." Morath slid onto the stool next to Gregor.

"Do you want the truth?" Gregor paused for a moment whilst he poured himself another drink. He could feel the warmth of his last drink giving his cheeks a reddish glow. "The truth is, I do not know where I hail from. I know not of my history. Where I have been or what I have done before the last few days that passed." A huge weight seemed to lift off him as he spoke his thoughts out loud.

"Were you in some form of accident?" Morath took a drink, his interest genuine. "I remember years ago, old Walliar's lad had a nasty fall off a ladder when he was fixing his pop's roof. Bashed his head on the block of ice on the ground, never seen blood like it. Was unconscious for near two weeks. Igraine said it was likely he would not wake, that the damage to his head would be too severe. She did not give up though, and she used her

magic on him throughout to keep him as well as she could. The gods must have took favour to him, as he woke up and he was fine, able to carry on living as if nothing had happened to him. Except for his memory. He didn't know who he was or anything that had happened before that fall. Still lives in the village. I'll point him out to you sometime." Morath continued his drink, the conversations in the background growing back to an audible volume.

"Did he ever get them back? His memories?"

"He didn't, but it helped that the people in the village knew him, as they could tell him the things he had done. The friends he had, the lady friends he had, if you know what I mean."

"What was the key to him moving on?"

"Acceptance. Looking at what he had control over rather than things he didn't. Some folk said his personality changed when he woke, but I think he didn't have the burden of being someone he didn't want to be. He was free."

Gregor thought on Morath's words. Was that the path he needed to walk? To accept that his memories were gone, and that he wasn't going to get them back? It was an easy enough concept to grasp, but the application was far harder than it seemed. He wasn't ready to let go. There was a constant tug pulling him back to the thick fog that clouded his mind. The more he tried to not think about it, the more the urge to find a way to regain his memories. Find the key to the lock which would give him access to his past. Maybe Igraine would be able to help him, or at least give him some advice, but for now, her focus needed to be on the girls. That was a conversation for another time.

"Thank you, Morath." Both men raised their glasses.

"To memories lost," Morath said.

"To the healing of those girls."

The door to upstairs swung open and Jura paced into the room, her skin pale as though her blood had been drained.

"What's the matter, are Freya and Shae okay?" Morath rushed to Jura to steady her as her legs began to buckle.

Gregor's heart sank.

"They are both alive, for now at least."

Gregor breathed a huge sigh of relief.

“Igraine is channelling her healing magic on them as we speak.” One of the villagers pushed a seat out for her, a drink ready and waiting. She gave him a smile and took a seat. As she brought the glass up to her mouth, trembling, she could barely keep hold of the glass. “It just got too much for me up there, seeing them in that state. Those poor girls.” Jura’s gaze became a blank stare as she stared across the table at the roaring fire.

Gregor knew that Freya and Shae’s horrific wounds would likely leave them scarred for life, their jaws crumbled and broken where the razor-sharp teeth of the dybukk had penetrated their gums. “Has Igraine said anything about their recovery?” he asked.

“She hasn’t. She’s been chanting her incantations the entire time I was in there. I tried asking her if they were going to make it, if they would be able to remember the ordeal. Those poor things don’t deserve this. Has anyone sent for their brother?”

“There’s nothing to be gained from him being here whilst Igraine is trying her hardest to save them,” said Morath, resting a hand tenderly on Jura’s shoulder. She raised her hand and placed it on top of his.

“I agree with Morath. The boy was barely coherent this morning when I spoke with him. He needs to rest until morning. Hopefully we will know more by then.” Gregor topped off Jura’s glass before pouring himself another. “I hope you don’t mind.”

“Drink as much as you like, there’s not a villager in town wouldn’t buy you a drink for fetching those girls back.” Jura attempted to smile but she seemed completely lost in her thoughts.

“Are you okay?” Gregor asked. Something didn’t seem right.

Jura remained silent, shrinking into herself.

“Jura?” Morath pressed.

Jura’s eyes began to well. “How has it come to this? Their mother slaughtered and Horus . . .” She slammed back her drink and then burst into tears, sobbing uncontrollably into her hands. Morath took up a seat next to her and hugged her.

“There, there.” Morath patted her on the back. “The girls are in safe hands with Igraine.”

“I promise you I will find who did this,” Gregor said. Hunting monsters and demons was one thing. Hunting humans was an entirely different beast altogether.

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CHAPTER
TEN

The night seemed to last forever even though for Gregor, it did not matter whether it was day or night. This body did not need to sleep. He lay on the bed for hours, staring at the ceiling, even tried closing his eyes to see if he was able to sleep, but his efforts were in vain. There had been no news on the girls prior to retiring for the night. When the last of the villagers left for their homes, Gregor remained with Morath to help clean up the tavern, happy for the distraction.

Now, his thoughts whirled around his mind like a cyclone, unable to move on, unable to switch his focus to anything else. The curse, the dybukks, Shae and Freya. Who had cursed that family?

The room where Igraine was frantically trying her hardest to heal the girls was just a couple doors down from him, and every so often Gregor would hear the sound of Igraine's chanting getting louder and louder. She spoke in a tongue that he could not decipher, though he suspected it was Elvish, for somehow he knew that Elvish magic contained healing qualities. Outside, the snow was constant and unforgiving, and Gregor hoped that Morath had made it home. The man had insisted that Fjorn, the god of ice, had pelted them with far worse storms than this.

"Just how many bastard gods are there," Gregor muttered, exhaling loudly. What he would have given for a decent night's sleep, to find some form of solace. For just a moment's reprieve from this eternal consciousness he had been 'gifted' with by the gods. Why would they leave him unable to sleep? Why would they allow an innocent family to be slaughtered, for demons to do what they had to those girls?

Gregor had to pull himself back from his thoughts as they darkened. Was he in fact cursed, or was it a gift that he had been given? His anger at the gods whipped up a storm that could rival the blizzard outside. He let out another groan of frustration and sat up. Waiting here was useless. He donned his boots and readied to go downstairs.

There was a timid knock at the door, quiet enough to not wake Gregor if he was sleeping, but loud enough to get his attention if he wasn't.

Gregor unlatched the door and pulled it open slightly to see a dishevelled looking Jura on the other side. Her eyes were purple and sagged, her face red and blotchy.

"It's the girls."

Gregor's heart sank once more at Jura's sullen words, fearing the worst.

"Igraine wants to see you." She shuffled away down the corridor again, locking herself in her room. Gregor walked down the short corridor to the bedroom where the girls were and took a deep breath before lightly knocking.

"Come in," a soft, reassuring voice called back to him.

Gregor opened the door, not sure if he could take what he was about to see.

When he entered, Igraine was placing wet flannel across the girls' brows. Her long, wavy black hair was matted with sweat, and her skin was soft and pale. Her emerald-green eyes hinted at Elven ancestry.

"You must be exhausted," Gregor said.

"My tiredness does not compare to the ordeal these two have been through. The gods must favour them though, as they both are still of this earth."

Gregor breathed a sigh of relief. "Will they be okay?"

"Their wounds are grave. The scars they will carry for the remainder of their days but yes, I feel my magic has been able to save them." Her gaze remained fixed on the twins. "I helped bring these girls into this world. I have helped most of the mothers in Garuvia bear their children." Igraine began to unfurl her sleeves that were rolled up to her elbows, but not before Gregor noticed the large black veins protruding down her arms.

"Your arms?"

"It is my affliction," Igraine explained, somewhat confused by Gregor's lack of understanding.

"Affliction?"

Igraine covered the dark veins, an air of curiosity about her. “Affliction from my magic. Using it takes its toll on my body, and I have used quite the amount. Tell me, Gregor, just where is it you come from? It is well-known that all users of magic carry such a burden.”

“I wish I could tell you.”

“Well, you are a curious man indeed. Not knowing where you are from, but knowing exactly where it was you needed to be.”

Gregor hadn’t thought of it like this.

Jura entered then, her arms folded around her thick green night robe.

Igraine smiled at her. “I need to rest and recover from using my magic. Would you stay with the girls? I pray it will only be a short while longer until they wake.”

Jura’s eyes flickered into life, her inverted body language reversing as if a huge burden had been lifted from her. “Oh, that is great news, Igraine.” She smiled as she embraced the healer. “Thank you both.”

She spun on the spot and before Gregor had time to react, she wrapped her arms tightly around him. Gregor placed his arms around her and hugged her back in surprise. She had a soft honey scent about her, with something else mixed in, something Gregor couldn’t quite recognise. The familiarity was on the tip of his mind, but he let this pass as welcomed comfort replaced the initial shock of her embrace.

“Gregor, I will come fetch you if they wake up,” Jura said. “Apeaus’s blessings to you, Igraine. You truly are a gift to us.”

Igraine raised her hood and made to leave. “I will see you both when I have recovered.” As she left, Gregor made to follow her.

“You too, Gregor.”

Gregor did not know what to say. He simply gave her an awkward nod before heading back to his room. He kicked off his boots and sat at the end of his bed, his sullen mood awakening into one of gratitude. He just needed to pass some time now and occupy his thoughts whilst they waited for the girls to wake. He took out piece of a branch he had stored in his pocket and began to whittle. This seemed to be the only way to achieve his goal of clearing his mind.

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CHAPTER
ELEVEN

The brisk knock at the door startle Gregor from the trance he was in. He had whittled the piece of wood into the shape of a rough horse. He had no idea how long he had been working on the piece of birch, but it had passed the time and occupied his mind whilst he waited for news.

"The girls, they're awake!" Jura's frantic knock tailed off as the sound of her footsteps scurried back up the hallway.

By the time Gregor had shot up and reached the door, only the tail of her nightgown could be seen re-entering the girls' room.

The hallway was brighter now that the sun had awoken, shining beams of bright light through the veiled windows. Gregor almost stumbled over his own feet as he hurriedly made his way to Freya and Shae's room. As he pushed the swinging door back open, his strength nearly forced the door off its hinges.

Startled by the noise, Freya and Shae shuffled towards Jura, who was perched on the bed next to them. She wrapped a tender arm around each one. Their faces were still bloodied and bruised from their possession, their eyes large with purple patches around them, sunken and tired.

"Who—who are you?" the girl on the left stuttered, struggling to form words.

"Why's Shae's face bleeding?" Freya said.

Shae glanced at her sister. "Your face is, too."

They began clambering in the bed, almost as if possessed once more. This time, though, it was shear panic and fear that moved them.

"Shhh, it will be okay, girls," Jura reassured them.

Gregor couldn’t help but think that if they could, they would have crawled inside Jura to hide from him.

“There, there,” Jura said as she hugged them, rocking them gently. “You are safe now. This man, Gregor, he saved you.”

“From what?” the girls spoke in tandem.

“Where’s Pa?” Freya said.

“Where’s Ma? And Colt?”

Jura planted a tender kiss on Freya’s head, who seemed more terrified than Shae. Stifling back her own tears, Shae shuffled away from Jura in an untrusting way.

“Do you remember anything from the other night? Anything at all?” Gregor’s voice was even more gruff than usual, and he cleared his throat.

“We heard a bang. Colt came into our room and told us to hide,” Shae spoke as her sister buried her head into Jura’s chest and continued to sob. “We hid under our beds like he told us, to play hide-and-seek.”

“Do you remember anything after that?”

“No.”

“How about you?” He pointed to Freya.

Freya turned her head and shook it, revealing bloody streaks down her face from her tears.

“Gregor, surely this can wait!” Jura scowled.

Gregor exhaled as he sighed loudly. He was grateful that neither girl remembered their possession. Given the pain and suffering they would have endured, the memories could have easily drove them to madness.

“We need to send someone to go and get Colt.” Jura looked at Gregor and then the door. Her face was worn with sorrow, her eyes darker than both of the girls’.

Taking the hint, Gregor left for Fjora’s house where Colt had been staying. He only hoped that the boy’s terror had subsided and that he would be more coherent after a night’s rest. Still, Jura was right, and he needed to know that his sisters were both safe.

Without grabbing his coat, Gregor made his way down the creaking stairs and into the empty bar. Musty, stale air with a tinge of aged ale filled his nose as he carried on through the bar and out of the front door.

There had been a thick falling of snow, which cascaded through the door as he pulled it open, falling over his boots. A good few feet had been dumped over the village thanks to the storm during the night. The slight

wind pressed against him and he savoured the feeling against his skin, but he remained numb to the cold. A woman trudged through the snow in front of him, pulling a small sled with some fresh produce on it. Her face was barely visible under the thick coat that she was hidden under, her pelt-covered boots disappearing underneath it.

"You will catch a death out here with no coat."

Gregor nodded and feigned a smile. "I will be fine." Standing in the doorway with nothing but his boots, pants, and a dirty cream shirt, Gregor didn't have time to explain that he did not feel the cold.

Each step was arduous and slow, and the village was only just creeping to life. Several folks traversed in the same direction with fresh produce, heading to the market. Even this weather didn't stop the villagers from being highly efficient. They had truly mastered how to exist in these harsh lands. All around him was white, some houses barely visible through the snow drifts, but people were out already digging away to unblock their doors and windows.

Snow still fell, but it wasn't thick, harsh, and unforgiving as before; it was gentle, soft, and powder-like. Holding out his hand, Gregor watched the snow land on his skin and melt as soon as it touched him. He could feel the light sensation of it landing on his skin and the subsequent water forming on his hand but nothing of the temperature. As he carried on through the village, eyes cast over him with concern or interest.

"That's him."

"He saved Horus's girls."

"The monster hunter."

Gregor passed the sled that he had brought the girls back with. Someone had removed it from the snow drift, and the yakulas were nowhere to be seen.

It didn't take him long to reach Fjora's house and Gregor rattled on the door, with a hard, brisk knock.

After a few moments, he heard the latch from the other side click, and the wrought iron handle turned.

"It's you. Is it true? Durian said he heard rumours you had found them." Fjora's eyes were wide with hope. The smell of freshly baked bread filled Gregor's nostrils.

He nodded and attempted a smile. "They are in The Red Dragon, I came to tell the boy."

Fjora glanced over her shoulder. “He keeps murmuring and his words do not always make sense. But he is getting better.”

“Please fetch him across as soon as you can. I will wait for you there.” With this, Gregor turned to leave.

“Sir.” Fjora stopped him in his tracks. “Thank you, you have done this village and Horus’s family a kindness.”

Gregor waved away the thanks. It wasn’t what he wanted now. He may have found the girls and saved them from possession, but he could not rest until he had figured out who exactly had put a curse on this poor family. Whoever had done it, there was nothing stopping them from doing it again.

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CHAPTER
TWELVE

As Gregor sat in an armchair in the corner of the room, watching over the sleeping girls, he couldn't help but wonder what was taking so long for Fjora and Colt to arrive. His broadsword lay perched against the wall next to him in case the dybukks returned.

Jura knelt by the girls' bed, clearly deciding that she also wasn't going to leave their side. She mumbled something quietly to herself that sounded like a prayer. Aside from her quiet murmurs, the room was peacefully silent, Freya and Shae's gentle breaths the only other audible noise in the room.

Gregor heard a soft knock at the door downstairs. "They are here." He stood from his chair. "I'll go and let them in."

When he opened the door, Fjora and her husband, Durian, stood side by side, expressions of apprehension etched across their faces.

"Where's the boy?" Gregor asked.

"He's here, he's just a little nervous," Durian replied.

The two of them stepped apart, slowly revealing Colt behind them, who was gripping the back of Fjora's coat tightly in his hand. Looking up from under his eyes at Gregor, he looked frightened.

"Come in, your sisters are upstairs, Colt."

Gregor stepped to the side to let them all in. As Durian passed, he planted a hand on Gregor's shoulder and gave him a nod of appreciation.

Colt didn't make eye contact with Gregor as he passed, instead looking timidly down at the floor.

"If you head upstairs and to the end of the hall, they're in the last room on the left." Gregor followed the three of them upstairs, unsure whether he

should warn them of his sisters' scarred faces. Would it be better to prepare them for what they were about to see? Feeling torn, Gregor opted to stay silent.

The three of them stopped as they approached the door, and Fjora leant down and whispered words of reassurance to Colt before resting her hands on his shoulders. Colt hesitated, but Durian gently nudge him forward as he leant over Colt to push the door open.

"Colt!" Shae said, her eyes widening with happiness at seeing her older brother.

Freya looked as though she were still half asleep. Sitting up straight, she rubbed her tired eyes and released a huge yawn. The yawn extenuated her freshly scarred face, her bloodied gums, and missing teeth.

Gregor glanced at Colt and couldn't help but feel pained for the boy as his colour drained from him, his gaze sinking to the ground once more.

Shae shuffled from the bed, her little feet giving the faintest of thuds on the wooden floor. She hobbled with a limp on her right leg, her knee almost buckling as she rushed towards her brother.

"Be careful, Shae," Jura said, the worry in her voice apparent.

Shae was determined, though, and continued towards Colt, who fell backwards into Durian's legs as she hugged him tightly. Durian steadied the two and Colt raised his arms tenderly around her, then pulled away. A short moment later, Freya had joined them. Colt seemed to hesitate and back away from the two of them as the girls began crying tears of happiness and grief.

As far as Gregor was aware, neither of the girls had been told about their parents' passing.

"I—I can't," Colt stammered, stepping away from his sisters.

"Colt, are you okay?" Fjora asked, but Colt pushed past her and made for the door.

"I told them to hide, I told them they would be okay." Colt's eyes were red with grief, his cheeks sodden with tears. "It's all my fault."

He shot through the door but Durian managed to grab his arm and stop him from running away. "Hey, you haven't done anything, you were really brave."

"What creature?" Freya frowned, wincing from the pain from the wounds on her face.

Durian froze, appearing to realise that the girls had been given little to no information. He attempted to keep hold of Colt who had begun to flail like a freshly caught fish.

“Get off me!” Colt cried.

“Where’s Ma and Pa?” Shae asked. “Colt, why won’t you hug us?” She stumbled towards him, struggling to understand the magnitude of the situation.

“Freya, Shae, maybe you should both come back to bed and rest,” Jura called, but the twins were becoming more and more upset. Jura choked up on her own words as she tried in vain to redirect the two of them.

“Where is Ma and Pa?” Shae shouted this time.

“They’re dead!” Colt snapped. “They’re both dead and it’s all my fault. I was there, I should’ve stopped it from happening.”

“There, there, there’s nothing else you could have done.” Fjora reached out to Colt but he ducked and stepped back into the hallway.

“Leave me alone, I want to be alone!”

“Come, Fjora, we will take him home. We’ll bring him back when he’s ready. Come boy, let’s go.” Durian escorted Colt away from the room. The boy’s sobs could be heard until they reached the floor beneath them.

“What does he mean, Ma and Pa are dead?” Freya asked, turning toward Jura.

“It means they are gone, poppet. They are looking down on you and will continue to as long as you walk this world.”

Freya lunged forward and buried her head into Jura, sobbing an agonising cry. Shae joined them, dragging her injured leg behind her.

The pain in their cries was unbearable. Gregor could feel a lump in his throat forming, the situation feeling too raw, even for him.

“I will give you some time with the girls,” he said. Feeling out of place, Gregor made to leave, unsure what to say or what to do. Aside from observing, there was nothing else he could do right now.

Something with this whole situation didn’t sit right with him. They needed to find who was responsible for this, and fast, before any more dybukks were summoned.

Gregor reached the bar and poured himself a shot of the Glegarian spirit before snapping it back, its sharp crispness instantly taking the edge off. To Gregor’s surprise, his eyes welled with tears as he thought about everything

Shae and Freya had been through. An overwhelming sense of grief came over him. Shadows peeled back in his mind, revealing a distant memory.

Gregor was kneeling by a bed, clutching the hands of his wife, her body still and silent as she drew her final breath in this world. Behind him in the darkened room, a midwife stepped forward, cradling two newborn babies.

He remembered. His wife had passed giving birth to their twin daughters.

Gregor sobbed on his own in an empty room and slammed back another drink of spirit to try and take the pain away. A fiery grief engulfed his heart. His eyes stung, his throat felt swollen as he choked on his tears, bereft.

Gregor cursed the gods above. “Is this what you want of me? To torture me with lost memories?” If anyone else had been in the bar, they would have considered him a madman. Gregor slammed back another drink, then another, conflicted. He had been desperate for signs of his past, but now he wanted to forget. Still, he searched and searched for further memories, but they did not reveal themselves. It was a cruel twist of fate to allow him to remember he had twin daughters of his own, but not allow him to recall their names.

The door to the tavern kicked open and a draught of cold air blew in, trailing in the powder snow from outside. Gregor turned to see Thodana standing in the doorway with her brother beside her. Dried, crusted blood caked Theus’s face.

“You’re alive!” Gregor smiled at the gaunt, tired looking pair. Their skin was as pale as the snow they stood in. “How did you get back so soon?”

“Th—Theus had the sled that he brought with him. We used his yakulas to keep us warm, but it was still f—f—freezing.”

“It wasn’t a pleasant journey b—b—back.” Theus moved into the room and immediately, threw a log onto the smouldering embers in the fireplace.

“I think I have something to help warm you up.” Gregor reached for the bottle of Glegarian spirit.

“Sit by the fire. We have much to catch up on.”

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CHAPTER
THIRTEEN

Gregor explained everything that had happened, only omitting the part about his memories. Those were too raw, too painful to discuss.

"Poor lad, it must have been too much for him." Theus took a gulp of his ale, letting out a huge sigh as he placed his tankard back on the table. "I am grateful to the gods that the girls have been saved from greeting the afterlife."

"It is not the gods we should thank, it is Igraine," Gregor said sternly. He still didn't trust Theus, and he put no effort into hiding it.

"Theus, can you go and check on Colt over at Fjora's?" Thodana asked, glaring at Gregor.

"At least let me finish my drink, sister. It has been a long day."

Gregor clenched his jaw. "Is that wise, Thodana?" he spoke through gritted teeth.

"Easy!" Theus raised his hands in a half-hearted manner. "I told you, I didn't have anything to do with this!"

Gregor feigned a smirk and puffed up his chest. He didn't like Theus and he still did not trust the man. Perhaps a few drinks would loosen his tongue.

"He is telling the truth, Gregor," Thodana cut in, attempting to calm the increasingly aggressive atmosphere. "Theus did not summon those demons."

"This is madness, Thodana. How can you stand there and defend him after what he did? He was at the cave!"

"I was looking for the girls, for fuck's sake! Thodana, this man may have been able to fight monsters, but he is out of his depth now." He turned

to Gregor. “I did not do this, Gregor, I swear. On my life, and my family’s honour.”

Gregor felt he had no option but to back down. There was something he didn’t like about Theus, but he couldn’t tell if this was because of the way he had greeted him when he first arrived or because he was capable of slaughtering a family.

“If not you, then we need to find who is responsible, and fast,” Gregor grumbled. “If someone has already tapped into dark magic, it may only be a matter of time before they do so again.”

The door to the inn flung open, almost ripping from its hinges as the back of it smashed into the wall. Durian stood panting heavily, his face panicked and pale.

“Fjora? Have you seen her?”

Thodana gazed at him dumbfounded. She was still thawing out from the cold but her attention was spiked in an instant.

“Not since you left with Colt,” Gregor said. “What’s wrong?”

“Something isn’t right with her, she’s been acting odd. Pacing around and muttering under her breath. Something has been tormenting her. She got angry at me and stormed off. I need to find her.’’

“We’ll come too,” Thodana said.

“Do you think she has anything to do with the demons?” Gregor muttered under his breath, not wishing to cause offence or distress to Durian.

“Only the gods know the answer to that question,” Theus said, throwing his thick coat back on before quickly following Durian into the streets.

Gregor and Thodana followed, pushing through the thick snow.

“We’ll be better if we split up.” Thodana pointed towards the centre of the village. “You go that way,” she told Gregor. “Theus is following Durian, and I will search the markets.” Pulling her hood over her head, Thodana set off.

Villagers looked puzzled as Gregor made towards the well. Not wearing a coat and unfazed by the cold, he was certainly drawing attention to himself. His frosted breath evaporated around him as he struggled to move at any speed through the snow. The sky was a pale blue colour, with no clouds on display, and though the sun beamed down on him, it did little to melt any of the frost and ice that had taken the village.

Gregor lost his balance and stumbled, faceplanting into the snow, which forced its way up his nose and into his mouth. Gregor quickly pulled his head back, revealing the usual white snow to be crimson. He had bust his lip and could feel the small cuts inside his mouth. Spitting blood onto the ground, he grumbled to himself and climbed back to his feet.

As Gregor stood cursing the snow, a woman's scream echoed just ahead. Picking up the pace, he pushed through the snow as blood continued to drip from his mouth. When he reached the opening, a small crowd had begun to gather by the well. The commotion drew the attention of others who quickly searched for the source of the screams. By the time he reached the group, there were eight people.

"What is it?" Gregor asked as he reached them.

"It's the well, it's filled with blood!" A woman sat trembling, the well's bucket on its side beside her. The blood that was inside it now poured into the snow, creating a sunken void.

Gregor peered down the well but it was too dark inside. He grabbed the bucket and threw it down, then started pulling on the rope until he felt it snag against something.

"Someone give me a hand!" he said, wrapping the rope around his wrist as he stepped back and began to heave the weight attached to the bucket. The burden lessened as two other men began to help in his effort. In his heart, he knew what this would be, but he prayed he was wrong. Within a few moments, his fears were confirmed.

As the body reached the top, other villagers rushed forward to grab her and pull her over the edge and onto the ground. Gregor rolled the blood-soaked woman's body onto her back. Her mouth was open with shock, her eyes widened with fear. Someone had slit her throat from one side to the other, sinew and bone on full display. Recognising her immediately, Gregor closed Fjora's eyes so that she could meet the afterlife. He closed his own eyes and cursed the gods. She had done no wrong. She did not deserve this fate.

"What's going on? We heard a scream." Thodana pushed through the gathering crowd of villagers, then dropped to her knees. "What bastard has done this!"

"Fjora?" Durian's pained voice broke as he stood beside Thodana. "Fjora!" Sliding through the snow, he dropped to his knees and wrapped his

arms around his dead wife. Theus walked up behind him and placed a hand delicately on Durian's back as he cried unconsolably into his cradled wife.

"What demon has done this? In broad daylight!" Thodana brought herself to her feet and stared deeply into Gregor's eyes. "I can't let anyone else in my village pass to the afterlife."

"It is not a demon responsible for this, Thodana." Gregor stared at her. "A demon attack would have been frenzied. Her throat has been cut with a blade."

"But that means . . ."

"We find the person who did this, we find the person who summoned that demon." Gregor surveyed the scene one more time before trudging back through the snow towards The Red Dragon. When he pushed the door open, he was greeted by Jura sitting at one of the tables. She had her head in her hands and she was sobbing.

"What's happened? Are the girls okay?" Gregor sat beside her, taking hold of her hands. They were soft but reddened like they had been rubbed raw.

Stifling her tears, Jura pulled her hands away from him. "The girls are fine," she said. "It's just all getting a bit much. Horus, his wife, the girls being possessed, and now Fjora. When is it going to end?"

Gregor stood from his chair when it hit him. "It was you, wasn't it?"

Jura sobbed into her trembling hands. "She was going to tell Thodana and Theus that I summoned the demons. I tried to reason with her, but she would not see sense. I had no choice."

"To slice her throat and throw her down the well!" Gregor's temper flared at Jura's unexpected confession.

"Don't you see? If Fjora told them that I summoned the demons, I would have been paraded around town and killed before nightfall."

"You killed a woman whose only crime was to care for an orphaned boy when it was you who slaughtered his family! Why, Jura? Why would you do all this?"

"I didn't—I didn't summon those demons. I saw Fjora approaching this morning. She saw me in the window and had a face like a gargoyle. I rushed down the stairs to see what the matter was. She told me that Colt had spoken to her, that she knew full well why I summoned the demons and that she was going to tell Thodana and Theus exactly what I had done. I

couldn’t let her go. I professed my innocence in all this, but she wouldn’t listen to me.” Jura’s sobs had taken over as she relayed what happened.

“So you cut her throat? If you were not involved with the dybukks, why would you kill Fjora to stop her from accusing you?” There was more to this than she was letting on, Gregor was sure of it. “What was it that Colt had told her?”

“That I was bedding Horus!” Jura slammed her hands on the table, startling Gregor. “I was, I loved him though. Even when he would stop visiting me in the night, I always knew it would be a matter of time before he came back. If she had told Theus and Thodana, they would’ve seen me as a woman scorned, that I did this as some twisted act of revenge.”

“You have killed someone, Jura! There will be a price to pay for that.” Gregor began edging for the door.

Jura sprang from her seat and reached for a small dagger that was concealed in her belt. “You can’t! They’ll kill me.”

“A life for a life seems fair to me.”

Jura let out a cry of anguish as she lunged for Gregor. He slapped one hand down, knocking her arm away before slamming his fist into her head. With a thud, Jura hit the ground. She groaned loudly, dazed from the blow. Gregor kicked the dagger from her grasp and the blade skidded to the other side of the room.

“I didn’t summon the demons, Gregor.” Her words stuttered out of her mouth. “You have to believe me.”

“If you didn’t, then who is responsible for this?” Gregor reached to help Jura up from the floor but something in the corner of the room caught his eye. It was as though light had reflected from a mirror, only there was no mirror in this room.

“I didn’t do it Gregor. I did not summon those demons!”

Gregor sighed. “I believe you,” he said, the realisation dawning on him.

“Why, how so?” Jura appeared somewhat confused by Gregor’s sudden change of heart.

“Because there’s a dybukk in this room and I believe it is here to kill you.”

No sooner had Gregor muttered the words, a clicking noise became audible from the corner of the room, like giant crickets in a field. The dybukk revealed itself and began clawing against the tables in a frenzy as it shot across the room towards them. Its joints clicked with each broken step

that it took, its rows of razor-sharp teeth bared. Taking a large leap, it flung itself at Jura, but Gregor was quick to it and caught it mid-air, grabbing hold of both its arms. It began biting and chomping, and Gregor was only just able to pull his face out of the way. He spun and let go of the creature's arms, flinging it over the top of the bar. Bottles smashed with the impact and the dybukk released a painful shriek as it clambered back to its feet. Gregor was weaponless, and the demon dived towards him again. Gregor braced himself but the dybukk's sharp claw sliced into his arm. A searing pain came over him as though a red-hot poker had been forced down his skin. His arm became numb almost instantly, but he used his other hand to repeatedly punch the dybukk in the side of the head as it teared against Gregor's chest with its claws.

Suddenly a chair smashed against the back of the demon, splintering into pieces from the force. The dybukk let out a shriek and turned to face Jura who had risen to Gregor's aid. Chattering its teeth together, it turned its head sideways before launching itself towards her. The two of them collapsed to the floor in a heap and the dybukk hacked and slashed at her, blood spraying up the wall as it cut through her skin with ease. Gregor jumped back to his feet and dived at the dybukk, knocking it aside. The dybukk pinned him to the floor and let out a blood-curdling shriek, then attempted to bite down on Gregor's face. With no other option, Gregor grabbed the creature's jaw, gripping it as tightly as he could. He grimaced in pain as the dybukk's teeth sank into his hand, but before it could bite down, Gregor seized the top part of its mouth. Its teeth sank deep into his skin and his own blood dripped down onto his face. He struggled against its vice-like bite, knowing he couldn't hold it off much longer. Gritting his teeth together, Gregor heaved against the creature's jaw, straining his arms against the beast. Slowly, the dybukk's jaw began to crack. Sensing a weakness, Gregor gave another big pull, and with a sickening crack, the jaw detached, spraying Gregor with warm, purple blood.

Gregor pushed the dybukk off him and it flailed aimlessly on the floor as it bled out until the clicking noise coming from its throat came to a rasping halt.

Gregor's hands felt as though they were on fire. He dropped to his knees by Jura's side, but there was nothing he could do to save her. Jura looked into Gregor's eyes as she gargled her own blood. The dybukk had managed

to land a fatal blow to her abdomen and her face. Panicked, she reached for Gregor. He held her hands in his as she took her final breaths.

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CHAPTER

FOURTEEN

Bursting into The Red Dragon, Thodana surveyed the bloodbath that had befallen them: Gregor knelt by Jura, and the dybukk with its detached jaw, lifeless, beside them.

"What the fuck!"

Theus appeared beside her and took in the scene. "We heard the roar of that creature and headed here straight away."

Gregor climbed to his feet amongst the broken glass and splintered wood. "It came for Jura, and it succeeded. She killed Fjora, but she didn't raise these demons from the ground. Someone else did."

"What? How do you know all this?" Thodana shook her head in disbelief. "How much more blood needs to be spilled in our village, Gregor. When will it end?"

Gregor thought about everything that had happened over the last few days. The answer hit him in the chest like an axe. He reached for the spirit on the bar and bit the cork, pulling it free from the bottle. He took a large gulp, then poured it over his hands, the alcohol stinging the puncture marks in his skin. He grimaced as he cleaned the wound as best as he could for now, then took another glug.

He shot across the room to the door, blood still dripping from his hands. "Follow me. This ends now."

Leaving a trail of blood, Gregor stomped through the snow, his shredded shirt and chest baring the claw marks from the attack. Four lives lost, two girls disfigured for the rest of their lives—and for what? A sordid affair between Horus and Jura?

It didn’t take long for him to reach his destination, and Gregor had no time for manners or politeness. He kicked open the door to Fjora and Durian’s house, tearing it from its hinges.

Durian was nowhere to be seen, but Colt sat rocking in a chair, muttering words under his breath.

“Is it done?” he asked. “Is she dead?”

“Why, boy? Why do this? To your own family!” Gregor felt sick. How could someone so young be capable of such atrocities?

“She deserved it. He did too,” Colt callously explained.

“What about Fjora? What about your sisters and your mother?”

“I didn’t mean for them to get hurt, I just wanted to make Pa and her pay for what they were doing.” Colt stopped rocking and focused on Gregor. “I saw them. I followed Pa to The Red Dragon. Been spending more and more time there. He thought I was in bed, but I snuck out and saw him with her.”

“Demons! You summoned demons!” Gregor roared at the boy’s stupidity. “How on this earth were you able to do that?”

Thodana and Theus had taken up formation behind Gregor, who was still standing in the doorway.

“I ran. When I saw them, I ran as fast as I could, and I found myself on the outskirts of Garuvia. I cursed them, I spat on the ground, and swore to the gods that I wanted revenge. A voice called out to me, as if answering my calls from the darkness. She said she could help me, she told me that she could help me get my Pa and Jura back for what they had done. She was nice, she told me that I didn’t need to worry, that she would take care of it. But that there would be a price to pay.”

Gregor shifted, a nervous edge coming over him. “What did she look like?”

“It was dark, but I remember her black, flowing hair, and her skin was pale. She had these strange tattoos up her arms like snakes intertwining.” Colt began rocking again, his eyes welling with tears. “I was angry at them, I wanted them to pay for what they had done, what they were doing. I didn’t know what the price would be.”

“Stupid boy!”

“Theus!” Thodana scolded her brother.

“There is something bigger at play here, Thodana,” said Gregor quietly. “I fear that this boy is but a pawn in a bigger game being played by the

gods.” The boy had been tricked by someone powerful into summoning the dybukks.

“She told me that I could control them, and I thought I did, but I never wanted them to hurt my sisters or Ma. Because of me, our ma is dead.” Colt showed little remorse for the other lives that he had taken, and this caused Gregor a great deal of concern.

“I didn’t want them to take my sisters. It’s because of me that they are the way they are now.”

A sharp sting to Gregor’s temple caught him off guard, causing him to wince from the discomfort. A flash of a memory bore into his mind, a painful burst of light followed by the silhouette of a woman. Gregor brought his fingers to the side of his head and massaged it gently as he attempted to ease the pain. He had a deep-rooted feeling that the two were related, that the woman who helped Colt to summon the dybukks was in fact the woman he had seen right before he woke up in the void.

“That’s why he got so upset when he came to see them,” Gregor said, turning to Thodana as he spoke. “Boy, this is really important. Is there anyone else in this village that you have ill feelings towards?”

“No, only them, and they’re both gone now.”

“Then the curse is broken, it is over. What was promised has been achieved, those who wronged you no longer walk this earth.” For some reason, Gregor knew that the curse would be lifted, having carried out the will of the boy. He just didn’t know why he knew this.

“Are you sure?” Thodana asked, looking uncertain.

“What about the boy?” Gregor was unsure of how the customs of this village would deal with such an atrocity. “He has been manipulated into this situation, something preyed on the darkness that his head had been turned towards.”

“He is a child. He will not lose his life, but these crimes cannot go unpunished.” Thodora pushed past Gregor and knelt in front of Colt. “You do understand this, Colt, that what you have done, it can’t be undone.”

“I understand,” he said.

“Theus, take him to the hall, we must convene the council to discuss what to do next.”

Theus guided Colt outside, the boy not showing any signs of resistance.

“Would you care to join the council?” Thodana asked.

“It is not my place to have a say in the laws that govern your people. You asked me to help you find the demon. I have done that, so now I will make my leave.”

“What about payment? What if you’re wrong, and these creatures come back?”

“There is a darkness coming. I think it has already landed. You have borne witness to it these last few days. My purpose is to find it and destroy it, to protect people from succumbing to it. Thodana, will you accompany me to The Red Dragon? I have something I wish to give to you before I leave, and one request to make as my payment.”

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CHAPTER
FIFTEEN

In his room Gregor, packed what few items he had into a satchel and placed it over his long coat. The blood stains from the dybukk had seeped into it, dying large sections of the coat a reddish-purple colour.

"Are you sure you need to leave, Gregor?" Thodana stood in his doorway as if she was ready to block his exit.

"The dybukks are gone, but that doesn't mean this darkness couldn't invade your village again. You need to be vigilant, Thodana. I can count on you for that." Gregor reached into his satchel and removed the wooden dagger that he had whittled. "Here, take this."

"A toy dagger? What am I to do with this?"

"That dagger has magic in it, from my blade. If you find yourself shrouded in darkness, it will glow."

"By darkness, you mean demons?"

Gregor nodded, then reached into his satchel and removed the small wooden horse he had whittled the night before, handing it to Thodana. "Those girls will likely never rest easy in the dark again. Give them this gift from me. It has the same magic."

"Thank you, for everything you have done for this village. You are a good man, Gregor. Your payment awaits you outside."

Gregor planted a hand on Thodana's shoulder. "And you are a good woman."

Making his way down the stairs, Gregor headed to the door and opened it to be greeted by a group of villagers who had come to say farewell. At least a dozen of them led by Theus took it in turns to grant Gregor safe passage, give him thanks, and wish him well on his journey.

“Your payment, Gregor.” Theus stepped to one side to reveal a carriage attached to six yakulas. “This should make travelling a little less arduous in the snow.”

Gregor offered his palm to Theus, and the men shook hands.

“Thank you, Theus.”

Gregor shuffled through the crowd and climbed into the front of the carriage, placing his broadsword beside him.

When he took the reins, the yakulas became animated as they began to huff and grumble between them. “Easy, now.” Gregor wrapped the leather reins around his hands and pulled back on them. “Yah!”

And with this, he set off into the frozen landscape. A new purpose, a reason to be alive.

Find the darkness, search for his daughters, and unlock the memories of his former life.

The end

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EPILOGUE

"When the gods brought about this darkness, demons were released into the world. What they had not accounted for was Gregor Yerrald. Tales are told to younglings that he would leave gifts imbued with magic to each village that he visited. That these gifts helped to keep the darkness away and stop it spreading across Levanthria. Keep a steady eye on the horizon for if you hear the sound of his sleigh, ridden by a man whose coat is stained red with the blood of the demons he has slaughtered. For his arrival is a double edged sword. If he is there it means he has come to help, but that means it is too late. For the darkness has already arrived."

Matlok Vern, Fables And Folklore 125KR

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Afterword

I hope you enjoyed this tale of Levanthria, I had a blast writing this story and creating Gregor. It does not end here though, please enjoy these two short stories of mine brought to print for the first time. Both are set in the world of Levanthria.

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A Loch of Grace and Greed

We wait by the foot of the mountains whose peaks stand unseen, bedded in clouds. A harsh frost clings to the sides of the rocks and pale snowdrifts build steadily at the base.

Sitting by a small fire, I press a whetstone against the stained metal of the hatchet that lies across my knees, grinding up to the edge of the blade. The heat from the fire kisses my legs and for the first time in a while, the numbness in my toes begins to leave.

“Care to explain what happened back there?” I recognise the voice of Eacharn Greum, his tone warning me of his displeasure.

I focus on my task and continue to sharpen my axe.

“Do not test me, Leandra.” His gruff voice cuts through the dark, startling me.

I reluctantly raise my head. I might be strong willed, but I am not stupid. Though Eacharn is my uncle, he will still make an example of me if I show disobedience towards him.

“Ostair threatened me, and I gave him reason not to do so again.” I show little emotion in my words. Ostair has had this coming for some time. He is a vile man who has long kept his eyes on me, and too often makes remarks about my form.

“Leandra, the man can barely walk!” Eacharn barks, his thick grey beard shining against the light that the moon offers. His face is weary and worn, and he carries a scar from the top of his nose down to his lower cheekbone. The mass of hair on his face makes up for the lack of hair on his head. “If you continue to strike at everyone who offends you, we will have

no one left to protect the village. You need to conduct yourself with more grace.”

“Grace!” I spit, “Would you be saying such words if I were your nephew and not your niece? Uncle, I ask to be treated no differently and I stand by this. How would you respond should someone make eyes at you, or threatening comments?”

“You would be wise to calm your words, Leandra,” Eacharn growls, “I grow impatient with your disobedience.” His chest puffs out and his cheeks become bloated with frustration.

A rush of fire fills my heart and I rise, my hatchet clenched tightly in my hand. “Groon!” I curse, part of me wanting to prove a point, part meaning every word of the insult. Within a second, his curled fist meets my cheek and I find myself flung backwards through the fire. Eacharn grabs me by the scruff of my clothes and raises me to my feet before taking hold of my throat.

As he pulls me closer, I can see the mess in his beard from his food, and the smell of ale lingers on his breath. I grab at his hands as I struggle to breathe. Eacharn is as powerful as a bear, and as dangerous; his hulking frame is twice the size of my own.

“You are only here because your ma begged me. Do not mistake this as kindness.” Eacharn’s grip around my throat tightens and I am completely at his mercy as my legs flail.

When he does finally loosen his grip, my legs crumble beneath me and I meet the dirt. I plant my hands and gasp for air, coughing and spluttering. I would do it again in an instant just to see the look of anger across my uncle’s face.

Eacharn spits at the ground in front of me, then turns and joins the others who are making idle song as they laugh and joke over ale. How they are meant to defend the village in such a state is beyond me, but our people are renowned for their fierceness on the battlefield as much as our love of ale.

I dust myself down, pick up my hatchet, and begin to press the whetstone against it again. I mutter under my breath all the while, cursing the very men of this village.

An hour passes and I sit staring into the flames, the roaring laughter from the centre of camp dampening to the drunken ramblings of the few men that remain. I hold a small fish embedded into the end of a skewer over

my fire, and the smell of the meat cooking gives me hunger pangs. My face still throbs from Eacharn's strike and my left cheek has swelled, affecting my ability to see properly. The pain pulsates in time with the beating of my heart, and I replay the confrontation with my uncle over and over in my mind. Each time, I think about the different ways I could have reacted to the situation that would have given me an upper hand. I loved a good fight as much as the rest of the warriors in our village but unlike them, I would sit quietly after, and reflect in order to better my reactions the next time.

The snap of a branch snaps me from my deepened thoughts and my gaze is drawn to the darkened trees on the outskirts of camp. There is a reason why we are based here, away from the village. We're not supposed to be fighting each other; we're lying in wait, preparing to face the soldiers that come this way. The southern region of Levanthria has some of the harshest winters in the realm, and our people rarely travel north Word has spread that the king's forces have moved south to gather supplies and people – including men, women, and children – to fight in a war that he wishes to rage against foreign forces. He is a false king in our eyes. One that we do not acknowledge, he holds no sway over the people of Bragoa. Our camp sits here to head them off, though the men of my village are foolish in their haste to make song and drink, leaving us vulnerable.

There is another snap of a branch and I know that these forces are here. I reach down and take hold of my hatchet.

Men and women scream battle cries as they rush from the darkness towards our camp, and I ready myself for the fight, my chest beating wildly like a drum, adrenaline coursing through me. The soldiers wear the king's colours of yellow and black. They raise their weapons, ready to swarm us.

A scrawny soldier reaches me first, his speed enabled by his slight frame. He takes a wild lunge at me with his sword. I know in an instant he is inexperienced in battle, and I easily duck the attack before slamming my hatchet into his back, the blade crunching through his bones. His blood sprays into me as I spin and slam my hatchet into another soldier's stomach. This first wave of infantrymen wears light armour, making them easier to dispatch. The arrival of the king's soldiers is met with the feral cry of the warriors from our clan. Even ale hasn't prevented them from responding. If anything, it has made them even more ferocious. Our people are larger; our men stand at between six and seven feet depending on age, and our women reach a height of six feet in adulthood.

The king’s soldiers are met by a wall of brutes, and my people begin to bury their warhammers and greataxes into the bodies of our enemies. As I continue to cut through the soldiers with ease, I am grateful for my leather armour, which allows me to move freely whilst offering me some protection. To my right I hear the roars of Eacharn, whose cries of anger drown out the screams of the men he fells like trees. He swings his warhammer like it weighs nothing. I hear the loud crush of bones as he slams it into the chest of a soldier who attempts to run.

“Do not let them get through!” He roars.

Bodies start splaying across the ground and blood drenches the forest floor before being trodden into the dirt, forming a clotted, crimson mud.

Not many of our warriors have fallen and the king’s men begin to thin until only a few remain. A woman rushes me, but I strike her face with the wood from my hatchet, knocking her backwards. I quickly flick my axe to my free hand and strike it across her throat, her gargled breaths pointless as she bleeds to death in front of me.

The last of the foot soldiers are taken out in the most brutal of fashion. Limbs are removed and bones are broken until all manner of screams of pain and anguish fade. The bellows of our warriors ring out as they cheer, exclaiming the initial victory. I am not naive enough to believe that this fight is done, and I take my opportunity to gather my breath whilst readying myself for the next wave.

“Brace yourselves, I hear something,” Eacharn roars loudly, taking charge of his men who are spread out over the makeshift battle camp.

I stand to the left of the field and count around twenty dead men and women around us. Only two of our warriors have fallen, which means we still have over forty in our ranks.

The battle cries of our men stop and for a moment there is silence within the field of dead bodies. I try to focus. I can hear feet making ground at speed and it grows louder as they approach. The next wave arrives on horseback.

They appear in droves through the trees, some with lances, some carrying pikes, some with swords outstretched to strike us down. I am alarmed by the sheer numbers that break through, and as the horses reach me, I roll forwards, dodging the pike that was pointed at my chest. I bring myself up and hack the hind leg of the horse and it keels over, catapulting its rider. No sooner does he hit the ground, a hammer is raised above his

head and slammed into his chest by Morgrim, Eacharn's second-in-command. His face is barely visible through his long, matted hair and his even darker beard.

I continue forward at a much quicker pace than the more heavily-armoured warriors of our clan, hacking at the horses' legs. I am then greeted by more foot soldiers who emerge from the woods, joining the cavalry. They are swarming us and now their numbers easily outmatch ours.

My hatchet bounces off the large metal shield of one of the foot soldiers as we exchange blows. The king's infantrymen carry better quality armour and weapons than us. This soldier wears chainmail. He strikes me with his free hand but I manage to grab hold of his wrist, preventing his sword from slicing me in half. Our eyes meet with equal rage. Hatred fuels us both and we continue to grapple to get the upper hand. He is strong but I can see the surprise in his face that his strength is equally matched by a woman. I can feel his arm begin to weaken. Finally, I slam my head into his while letting out a battle cry of my own. He staggers back and loses his footing and I am quickly upon him. I swing my hatchet down, time and time again, until his bloodied face does not resemble that of a human anymore. I pant franticly as I embrace the wildness of my people. Those that attack us will know our fury and will feel our wrath.

A searing pain greets my shoulder and I find myself staring up at the stars above. Raising my hand, I feel the wood that is buried deep in my flesh. Arrows begin to fire towards us. From where I lie, I see our warriors beginning to fall as they are sprayed with the cowardly weapons.

I force myself to sit up and survey the battlefield, Ignoring the arrow that maims me. Blood courses out from my shoulder, the injury causing my shoulder to stoop. Our warriors are dropping quickly now and there is no hope that we will win this. There are arrows embedded into Eacharn's body but this does not deter him. He moves forward through those that oppose him as he strikes them down one after the other with every swing of his warhammer. No longer does the forged metal shine with the craftmanship of our people; it is soaked in the blood of our enemies, of those that wish to take our people by force. As I stand, another bolt hits me in the same shoulder, this one slightly lower. It takes my breath away but I manage to stay myself from falling over. My left side now injured beyond use, I cut down whoever comes close enough with my hatchet.

There are only a few of us still standing now. We continue our fight against an enemy that we have never wronged, and my hatred for them grows even deeper. Eacharn roars as he takes down three men at once with an almighty swing of his hammer. The gods must be watching down on us with pride.

A man moves toward Eacharn who is almost equal in size. He is heavily armoured and his skin is as dark as the night sky. I have never seen his kind before, but I can tell from his form that he is of elven heritage. Eacharn casts eyes on him and begins his charge.

“Leave him to me,” the man roars at the soldiers who obey without fail, lowering their weapons. This man holds rank over the others, and I pray that Eacharn will best him in combat.

He points his greatsword at Eacharn who reaches him within seconds. The two of them begin trading heavy blows with one another, but my uncle is weakened by the arrows that now decorate his body. Eacharn swipes his hammer at his foe’s head, but he misses, and his momentum swings him past. The elven man swipeshis greatsword at Eacharn who lets out a scream as it cuts through his back with ease. He drops to his knees and our eyes meet across the battlefield. Eacharn plants his hammer to the ground to steady himself from falling. The elf stands behind him and raises his sword high, gipping the hilt with both hands, delivering the killing blow. I do not cry for him, I do not shed a tear for his loss of life – I shed tears for the pride I share for my uncle who has fought with honour. He may have always been a brute towards me, however he has fought until the end to protect our clan.

The sword is pressed deeply through the back of his neck, and blood begins to pool in his mouth. At least he has been given an honourable death with his weapon still in his hand.

“Let me avenge my fallen brothers and sisters!” I raise my head to the skies as if I speak to the gods. It is only them that can save me now. “Let me spill the blood of those that are responsible for this!” My words are true but there is no one to hear them. I am surrounded by death. The wailing of my tribe is all I can hear as they are slaughtered on the battlefield.

It is at this moment that a third arrow slams into my chest. I feel no pain as I meet the blood-soaked mud.

I embrace the darkness that awaits me.

I am barely conscious, but I can feel the pressure on my leg as I am dragged through the thick, congealed mud. I struggle to open my eyes, my body burning as if I am engulfed in flames. I force my eyes open. My vision is blurry, but I can make out the silhouette of a stooped figure. With surprising strength, she is dragging me across the ground with a rope.

"What are you doing, where are you taking me?" My voice is barely a whisper as I choke on the pooled blood in my mouth, the taste of iron making me want to vomit.

The old hag merely hums a song as if she is singing me a lullaby. I am unable to make out the words that she is muttering, and my consciousness drifts, my head is dizzied. I am left wondering why I have not already greeted the afterlife.

"What are you doing?" I try once more but the blood in my mouth bubbles. The words I try to form are not the same as the rasping air that leaves my throat. Reaching out in vain, I flail my arms as they flop around limply, like they do not belong to me. I try to grab hold of anything I can, with no success. I think about my uncle who has fallen and worry about the fate of those left undefended in my village. The sense of hopelessness consumes me. I do not cry easily, yet I feel my eyes pool with tears as my mind transports me to the darkest of places. It does not take much to imagine what those soldiers will be doing to the women and children, all manner of monstrous acts.

I let out a sigh and my arms collapse above me. My strength is gone, and I feel broken, my pain agonising as the old hag continues to drag me through the dense trees.

All the while she continues to hum a melody that I am unfamiliar with. It does not soothe me in the slightest – if anything, it raises my concerns even more.

Where is she taking me?

Even when humming, the crackle in her vocal cords is clear, as if she has spent all her years inhaling smoke. The hag continues steadily, dragging me along, my body grinding against every rock, broken branch, and spiked shrub that we meet.

"Kill me," I rasp, the blood in my mouth spilling over my face. There is no hope for me now; my wounds are too far gone, the crimson trail I leave behind a sign that my body runs dry. "Please." This is pain like I have never

endured, the most undignified I have ever felt. There would have been honour in dying on the battlefield, but there is no honour in this.

The old hag stops in her tracks. At first I think this is to oblige my request for her to end my life. I take shallow breaths, each one getting harder and harder. My head is throbbing, the world around me pulsating as the light continues to fade into darkness. I know not whether this is because of the falling sun or my loss of consciousness. All I know is I want to be released from this world, from this pain.

“We’re here,” the hag’s voice creeks, like an ancient tree cracking as it bends in the wind. She drops the rope from her shoulder and turns to face me, her features hidden by the shadows.

“What do you want from me?” I am unable to move, my body paralysed from blood loss. I cling to life now, and I know death is not far.

“What do I want, dear?” The old hag seems confused by my question. “I merely respond to your request to the gods.” She grabs hold of my legs and begins to pull me once more. The darkness lifts as we escape the trees, opening up to the light of the moon.

In this instant, I know where she has brought me.

“The loch?” I am bemused as to why I have been dragged from the battlefield to the Loch of Bragoa.

“Why, to heal you, dear.” She casts me a smile, revealing her cracked and broken teeth. “Was it not revenge that you wanted? Against those that have done this to you? To those that have slaughtered your clan like cattle?”

I do not see how I can possibly be healed from these wounds. “Why the loch?” I croak.

I know this loch well. There is no life here – its waters are full of disease and decay, and those that drink from the loch end up sick. My ancestors tried fishing these waters when they first formed our village, but for years we have always avoided this place. I can’t bring my head around why I would be brought here, and I have no idea how this hag intends to heal me.

I feel the rocks scraping against my back as she drags me to the edge of the valley, a sheer drop between myself and the water. The world grows darker. I attempt to roll to my side and relieve the pressure on my lungs, but I have nothing left. My body is a vessel devoid of life.

Beside me, the hag raises her hands to the clouds and begins chanting words that I do not understand. “Septum, Vorah, Krako, Ramora!” Her

words echo loudly over the loch, her croaking voice suddenly more assertive, more powerful. “Septum, Vorah, Krako, Ramora!” She bellows once more, with even more conviction. The clouds above begin to separate and swirl as if it is the hag that controls them. Behind them the sky turns a deep purple.

“SEPTUM, VORAH, KRAKO, RAMORA!” She brings her hands over me. At once, I feel as though lightning from the storm clouds strike me and my body begins to burn with intensity as if I have been thrown into a volcano. My jaw clenches tightly as my body begins to convulse violently. I bite down involuntarily, hard enough that I feel my teeth shatter. I have no idea what witchcraft the hag is using but it is something I do not welcome. The agonising pain I was feeling as I was dragged here is replaced by something much worse.

My body continues to shake, and through the hag’s chants I hear a crack. I scream out in pain as the bones in my legs shatter. Blood sprays from my mouth as more bones break, starting at my ankles and slowly making way up my legs to my thighs. It stops for a moment, the thunderous clouds subsiding as if the storm the hag summoned has passed. I am gasping now, and it feels as though the air is becoming thicker than the blood that I am drowning in. In this moment I pray for death, for the pain to stop, for all of this to be over. Then another crack echoes over the loch. This time it is my ribs breaking, and I scream with heightened agony.

I try to ask the hag why she is doing this, but no words leave my mouth. My throat feels as if it has been sealed shut, and I begin to pass out.

The hag casts one final look over my broken body, her cracked skin and deep wrinkles examining me like an artist would a painting. “You will survive this dear. The gods have allowed it. But not without a price. These tainted waters are where you will live. The waters that poison everything else are what will keep you alive. Your years will far stretch beyond that of mortal men. You will have the revenge that you seek.” The hag places her foot on my side, and I feel that where my ribs should be is now soft, as if my bones have completely disintegrated.

“You will walk the land every five years. It is in these moments you will have your revenge, it is in these moments you will paint the mountains with the blood of those that have done this to you.” She pushes her foot against me and I feel weightless as I plummet down the side of the rock face.

Slamming against the loch, I hear my skin sizzle like water being cast onto a fire. The black waters are freezing but soothe me almost immediately. The harrowing pain begins to subside, the sharpness of the cold jolting my eyes open. Suddenly I feel very much conscious and aware of my surroundings. I feel myself sink down into the depths, and I find myself able to see, despite the darkness. I can make out the rock formations that surround me. A newfound energy strengthens my limbs and I wave my arms to try and prevent myself plummeting even deeper, holding my breath. I attempt to kick my legs to slow my descent, but something doesn't feel right; they move as one, as if my bones have been fused together. I kick in a wild panic. Searching below for the source of my entrapment, my eyes widen at what I see: my legs are no longer there. They have been replaced with what looks like the scales you would see on a sea creature. I scream but the sound is muffled, and only bubbles escape my mouth. I kick again, desperate to reach the water's surface. I find myself moving through the waters quicker than I could have before tonight. A tight knot forms in my stomach as I struggle to hold my breath any longer. I'm going to drown. I flick my tail and thrash, but it is too late. Against my wishes, my body tries to take in air, and I gasp.

A strange sensation runs through my ribs as if water passes through them. A moment later, the tight knot in my stomach disappears and I find myself breathing freely. The water is pulled inside me through my ribs, and it feels exhilarating. The coldness seems to heal my broken bones, giving me the feeling of new life. I sit motionless in the water, taking in breath after breath, each one revitalising my body. My panic having subsided, I now stare out at the vast landscape around me.

This is my new home.

Tethered to a new body, I am cursed to live in these waters. It is a curse that I embrace and I am grateful to the gods. Five years I must wait, according to the hag. However miserable my life might be down here, it will be worth it for the blood that I will spill in revenge for the attack on my village. The king and his armies will pay for the slaughter of my people.

I am Leandra Frostworn, and I will have my vengeance.

"She moved through the battlefield with the grace of a goddess, her blades dispensed upon any man or woman who stood in her way. Let it be put to the records that it was the greed of the king that created this monster.

That it was he who unleashed this daemonic creature into this world. The creature who now stalks the land making her fury known every five years. The Beast of Bragoa”

-The Legends of Bragoa: Jordell Torvin, alchemist and bookkeeper of the great Temple of Askela. 256KR

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DUST

“Wake up”

Her voice is soft and reassuring. My head splits as I struggle to open my eyes and I see a vague outline of the woman who wakes me. Bringing my hand up to inspect my head, I struggle with the chain that binds my wrists together.

“Where are we?” I stutter, my voice croaky as I come to. I sit up and take in my surroundings. “Where’s Matil?” My mind races to my partner who I was with before waking up in this dirty room. It is dark, with only a glimmer of light entering the room from a small window high above us. There is a dampness in the air and a foul smell as if someone has emptied their bowels near us.

“Shhh, try and keep your voice down.” The woman places her hand over my mouth, her skin soft against my face. “Krey, are you nearly done?” she looks over her shoulder and whispers to someone else in the room. A soft glow of light behind her brings her face into focus. Her blond hair is tied up onto the top of her head, and her large, alluring green eyes are fixed on me beneath furrowed brows.

“This isn’t an easy lock to pick, Troya.” Krey’s hands are placed over the lock of the door, a magical glow emitting from his fingers. “Is he awake?” he asks, his focus remaining on his task.

Troya offers me her hand and I noticed that she is also bound with chains. I take hold of her hand and she leans backwards, helping me to my feet.

“Where are we?” I whisper.

“Black market traders,” she starts. “They come in the night and take us from our homes.”

“But why?” Up until now I have lived a peaceful life within my village. We have not wronged anyone or had any conflict with our neighbours. In fact, we keep to ourselves. Everything is so much easier when you keep your existence hidden. “This doesn’t make sense,” I stutter. “What about my village? Have you heard of anyone else from Ritu being here?”

“Krey and I woke up here just like you. There were more of us, but they have been taking us out of here one at a time. Have you not heard the stories of our villages being raided?” she asks. “We thought we were prepared, but they used smoke to get to us. We didn’t stand a chance.” Troya’s voice is pained and for a moment her gaze seems to disappear into distant thoughts. “Little do they know that Krey has a rare magic. He is using it to help us escape. Tell me, what is your name?”

“Pite,” I answer tentatively. “Do you hold magic?”

“I do.” Troya casts a look at her bound hands and the chains begin to glow, causing her skin to sizzle as they press against her. She grimaces and stops trying to cast her magic. “They have done something to these chains. Only the gods know what.” She mutters curses under her breath. The smell of her singed skin lingers in the air painfully. “Do you possess magic?”

I nod, but after seeing what these chains have done to her, I have no desire to test my own resolve against them. “Why do they not burn against his skin?” I point towards Krey who continues to channel his magic into the lock of the door.

As I say this, Krey drops to his knees and lets out a groan of pain that echoes around the room. Troya rushes over to catch him as he falls. It is not his magic illuminating the room, it is the chains around his wrists, which burn white.

“Krey, are you okay?”

He cringes. “The lock is broke.”

“At what cost?” she muses.

“I would pay any price to regain our freedom. This pain is temporary. When we find a healer, they will be able to aid me in my recovery.”

I move to help Krey to his feet. He reaches out blackened hands that are cracked with congealed blood, and he winces as I take hold, showing his resolve through gritted teeth.

“What now?” I glance at the door. “Who knows what’s out there.”

“Those bastards are going to pay for what they have done to us.” Troya makes her way to the door and pulls it towards her slowly. The door creaks, drawing further attention. A soft glow from the torches outside illuminate Troya’s face. “There’s no one out here. Come, we need to move quickly.” She pokes her head out the door for one final glance before heading out.

Krey and I follow her out into the corridor, which is wider than I would have thought. Torches line the walls, lighting our escape. Multiple doors fill the walls leading to what I presume are further cells where people of my kin are being held.

“What about everyone else?” I stop, conflicted by the prisoners we pass as we make our bid for freedom. Could Matil be behind one of these doors? Could he be bound and chained as I was? Sorrow overcomes me as I think about him and the circumstances we have found ourselves in.

“And how are we meant to break the locks?” Troya snipes. “Look at what it has done to my brother.”

“My sister is right. As much as we want to break people free from these dungeons, right now, we can’t. We will be better to find where we are and return with our fighters.”

“Or find the keys.” It doesn’t sit well with me, leaving our people here. “Only the gods know what our captors want with us. I can’t leave our people to a fate of which we know nothing.”

“His words are true, Troya. Perhaps we should search for the keys to these doors.”

Troya sighs, then turns and heads up the corridor. “Come on, let’s go. We will achieve nothing standing here.” I count twenty-three doors as we slowly continue our trail, following the torchlight until I see a stairwell leading upwards.

“Over there.” I point to the circular stone staircase, and we begin to climb. We do this slowly, not knowing what awaits us at the top. My chest grows tight from the exertion. When we reach a doorway at the top, Troya holds out a hand to stop us.

“There’s one of them,” she whispers, a hatred burning in her eyes as she scowls across the room.

Following her gaze to the far side of the room, I see a jailor in a black tunic sitting in front of a table. He is slouched in his chair and his legs are stretched out. A noise reverberates from him that sounds like snoring.

“The high priestess grants us a kindness, sister.”

We edge across the room towards the sleeping jailor as quietly as possible.

“Wait here.” Troya climbs up onto the table and begins searching the desk.

She is louder than I would have liked, but does not appear to be disturbing the jailor. Her head pops over the top of the desk towards us, a smile on her face. She jumps down and reveals a small key. “Hold out your hands.”

Krey and I stretch out our arms and Troya unlocks the chains that bind us. When the chains drop, my arms feel as light as air. The metal hits the cold stone underfoot and my heart jolts. The jailor stirs and begins to mumble words from his sleep.

“Sorry.”

Krey takes the key from his sister and removes her bindings. As I rub my wrists to relieve the tension, I glance at Troya and see her doing the same with her charred wrists. I can’t help but wonder just how many times she tried to use her magic while those chains were bound around her. Krey places his on the ground slowly.

“He has the keys to the doors on him.” Troya points at the jailor who continues to snore, blissfully unaware of our presence.

“Asleep on the job again!” a deep voice echoes through the room and causes me to jump. A guard on his patrol stands in the doorway.

Panicked, I look at the other two; we have nowhere to hide.

The jailor startles awake.

“Fuck!” He sits upright and wipes his hands over his face, then his eyes land on the three of us.

Troya acts first, summoning a thunderous spell with her hands. Before the jailor has time to move, he is hit in the face with a blast of energy that sends him crashing over the back of his chair. He lets out a whimper and brings his hands to his face, screaming in agony. Troya spits at him before firing another blast of magic. His body begins to crack and convulse. His tunic burns away, revealing his charred skin.

Krey rushes toward the other dumbfounded guard and jumps up, bringing his hands to his side before firing a blast of energy forward. The force slams the guard into the wall, and he crashes into the ground, letting out a large roar in the process. It is as if a storm has entered the room as gusts of wind and air whip up around us.

These two possess elemental magic. Their tribe must be part of the wind-walkers. Krey continues his advance on the fallen guard and forces his hand over the man's eye as he seeks to regain his footing. Then as Krey channels his magic and emits a contained force of energy, blood spurts out of the guard's eye and he slumps to the ground. No one can withstand pressurised magic in such close proximity.

"I can hear footsteps, more guards are on the way!" Krey bellows.

"We have nowhere to run," I call back. We can either go back down the stairs or head towards the guards.

"Then we will fight!" Troya whips up magic in her hands as if she holds clouds between her palms, forks of charged lightning crackling within. As two guards reach the doorway, she releases her spell and the lightning hits each man square in the chest, dropping them in an instant. They groan loudly at the impact. Krey jumps on top of them and fires pressurised air into their faces, silencing them.

"Let's go!" he commands.

I can see from their precision that these two are warriors within their tribe, and it is clear they have mastered their magic. Unlike their battle-ready powers, I have only ever used mine in my local quarries.

Krey finds himself hurled backwards as something crashes into him. I rush across the room to help him and find he has been hit with a net.

I pull at the material, but I can't tear it. Troya comes to my side and tries to use her magic, but Krey shrieks in pain. The net must be imbued with the same magic as our chains.

"Go sister, get yourself to safety," Krey pleads, his voice breaking.

"I can't leave you!"

A blast of magic ploughs in-between the two of us and flings me across the room. I crash into the charred body of the jailor, the heat of which is nauseating. Mages enter the room now, their arms outstretched. My head rings from the blast and my body aches.

"Don't get any more ideas!" one of the mages scolds.

Troya jumps towards them head-on, but they fire another spell at her and she is slammed to the ground. As she tries to stand, a guard presses his foot into her back and she cries out in pain. As blood begins to leave her nose, I fear he will squash her where she lies.

I begin to channel my own magic and the room starts to shake violently.

"He's an earth-shaker, stop him!"

A guard rushes at me but I pull a stone up from the ground using my magic and slam it into his face, stopping him in his tracks. It hurts me to cast but I have little option. I pull more stones from the floor and hurl them at our enemies.

One of the mages casts a barrier spell to protect them from my assault, then fires at me. His magic catches me in the shoulder, searing me with agonising pain. I shoot another stone at him, and this time, he isn't able to block it. The snapping noise of his jaw is most satisfying.

"Get him before he sets these walls down on us all!"

Another blast hits me, then another, and I find myself unable to stand. As I crash to the ground, my head slams against the crumbling stone floor and my vision fades. Footsteps move towards me. Troya reaches for me as she continues to cry out in pain. My vision draws dark, and I slip into unconsciousness.

When I come to, I feel a pressure in my arms. I look around to find myself suspended in the air. My arms are shackled to wall, my shoulders stinging where the magic hit me. My muscles burn, and my head feels as though it is about to implode.

To my right, Troya is also suspended, awake but silent. Her cheeks are red with rage, her face bloodied. To my left is Krey, badly beaten and hanging limply from the wall.

"You fairies can be tricky, to say the least," a woman's voice taunts us. "Still, we have found a way to make use of you." She wears a red dress, and red curls escape from the front of her hood. "I will give you dues, you put up a fair fight. Three guards, one jailor, and a mage killed within moments. The magic you possess intrigues me more than you realise."

"Why don't you remove these chains so I can show you more?" Troya's eyes are fixed on our captor.

"What would be the logic in that? I have seen exactly what you are capable of."

I try to pull from my chains but it is to no avail. "What is it you want from us?"

"Your magic, of course. It is all about the magic that you possess. We are in desperate need of magic and so far, fairies have refused to help us. I did offer diplomacy."

“You call this diplomacy!” Troya spits. “You are a monster. What have we ever done to you or your people?”

“Aren’t you the feisty one,” the woman teases. Her words are soft and almost calming, despite the violent situation we find ourselves in. “If your elders had listened, I would not have been forced to take the actions I have. Through research, I have found a way to harness the magic within you.”

“What do you mean?” I ask.

“I mean if the fairies will not lend King Athos their magic in a time of war, then I have no choice but to take it from you,” she sneers, her face still hidden in the shadows.

“And how do you propose to do that?” Troya asks, all the while fighting against the chains around her wrists.

“Oh, you want to see.” The woman beckons a guard to her side. “These fairies don’t believe me.” She steps forward from the shadows and lowers her hood, revealing her vibrant red hair. Her thin face draws down to her pursed lips. She bites down on her bottom lip as though musing over her thoughts. “The question is, who wants to go first?” She points a finger at me. “Which one shall I choose.” She stops, her finger cast in the direction of Krey. “Wake him up! We don’t want him to miss the spectacle.”

The guard beside her steps forward and opens a bottle of something, then places it under Krey’s nose. In a matter of seconds, Krey begins to murmur, his breathing heavy and rasping.

“No, not Krey, take me,” Troya cries, fighting against her bands. She grimaces as she tries to summon her magic, but her wrists sizzle and she stops, blood trailing down her arms.

“According to the report, this one killed three of my guards. I would say he is more powerful than you two.” The red woman steps towards Krey and lifts his chin until their eyes meet. “Besides, this one’s life is draining from him. We need to act before his light snuffs out and his magic is wasted.”

The guard unlocks the binding from the wall and Krey drops like a stone. His ankles crack as he hits the floor, and he cries out in agony. The guard picks him up and carries him to the edge of the room.

The woman raises her hand into the air and with a flick of her wrists the torches around us illuminate, revealing us to be in what looks like a forge.

“Let him go! Please stop! Don’t do this!” As Troya attempts to use her magic again in pure desperation, more blood pours down her arms.

My heart pounds wildly against my chest as I begin to realise what is about to happen. My mind races to Matil. Is this a fate that has already befallen him? Is he somewhere inside this wretched place? The woman opens what looks to be a furnace, and the guard throws Krey inside, then shuts the door behind him.

“Stop, you can’t do this! Krey!” Tears stream down Troya’s blood-soaked cheeks.

Krey pulls himself up to a porthole within the furnace. “Be brave, my sister, be brave.”

The woman places her hands on the furnace and begins to channel her own magic. Heat rises from her as she slowly increases the temperature.

I can see Krey through the porthole. He fights against the rising temperature, trying his hardest to remain dignified and not show our captors fear. The temperature continues to rise until Krey lets out an ear-splitting scream, and his skin starts to blister and bubble.

“Stop!” Troya screams, her voice breaking.

The woman’s eyes are wide as she continues to channel her own magic into the furnace.

Flames erupt inside and Krey disappears. His screams, however, continue, and I can hear him banging on the walls. The sickening screams continue until they are replaced only by the sound of the roaring flames.

Troya cries inconsolably as she heaves and pulls against her chains. “I’ll kill you, I’ll kill you for this!”

The woman smiles and snaps her fingers. In an instant, the flames disappear. She leans forward and opens the hatch of the furnace, placing her hand inside. I have only just met Krey, but I can see that he was a true warrior and showed honour until the end.

The woman moves towards us with her hands behind her back, her face dark and sinister.

“Why? Why would you be so cruel?” I ask. The fate given to Krey was agonising and torturous. The woman seems to have enjoyed doing that to him. Who knows what else she is capable of?

“I’ve already told you, I want your magic.” She stops in front of Troya and unfurls her fingers. “You see, here is the ashes of your brother. I, however, like to give it another name.”

“You’re a monster!” Troya screams, her face a mixture of grief and rage.

“This is dust.” She takes a pinch of Krey’s ashes between her thumb and finger and clicks them together. The dust ignites and a bolt of pressurised air fires forward into Troya’s shoulder, piercing her skin. Then the red woman removes a small bottle from her cloak and drops Krey’s ashes inside.

“Magic I can bottle up. Can you imagine what I can do with this? I have no doubt that if we capture enough fairies, we will soon be able to end this war. If only your elders had listened.” She turns her back and pulls her hood over her head, making to leave. “You know what to do.”

She slams the door behind her, leaving us to our fates.

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